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Capital ready for Kanwar Yatra



NATION: Pg 5

Wave of NEET protest sweeps across states



FILM: Pg 12

Ranbir Kapoor felt 'fear' playing Lord Rama

SOURCES INDICATE PRADHAN IS UNLIKELY TO RESIGN

Pradhan's resignation remains sticking point in govt-CJP talks

Centre signals nod to two demands, CJP holds ground as Centre seeks more time on Pradhan's resignation; youth vow to intensify agitation

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The standoff between the Centre and the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) continued on Friday even as the second round of negotiations concluded without a breakthrough on the protesters' principal demand, the resignation or removal of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

While the Centre sought time till Saturday afternoon to respond, thousands of students at Delhi's Jantar Mantar vowed to continue their agitation, declaring that the movement had reached a point of no return.

The nearly two-hour meeting at the Constitution Club was attended by Union Ministers J.P. Nadda and Jitendra Singh and a CJP delegation led by Ashutosh Ranka and Saurav Das.

The delegation submitted three key demands, the resignation or dismissal of Dharmendra Pradhan, Rs.1 crore compensation for families of



Union Ministers Jitendra Singh and JP Nadda during a meeting with Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) spokespersons Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka to find an amicable solution to the outfit's demands related to exam irregularities, at the Vithalbhai Patel House, in New Delhi, on Friday

NEET aspirants who allegedly died by suicide, and withdrawal of all FIRs and legal proceedings against protesting students, besides a written sovereign guarantee that no similar cases would be filed in future.

Speaking after the meeting, CJP leaders said, "The

government had expressed in-principle acceptance of the compensation and legal protection demands but requested additional time to deliberate on Education Minister's resignation." Another meeting has now been scheduled for Saturday afternoon.

However, even before

the next round of talks, government sources indicated that Pradhan was unlikely to step down. According to the sources, the Narendra Modi-led government "stands firmly behind the education minister and believes that resignation is not the solution." The sources also asserted that action against

paper leak syndicates and reforms in the National Testing Agency (NTA) would continue.

Addressing supporters outside the protest venue, Ranka said the movement had gone beyond seeking assurances and was now demanding visible accountability. He said young people

CLOSER LOOK

» Union Ministers Nadda and Jitendra Singh meet CJP delegation

» CJP demands Pradhan's removal, Rs 1 crore compensation, FIR withdrawal, legal protection

» CJP says Centre showed in-principle support for compensation and legal safeguards

» Centre says crackdown on paper leak syndicates and NTA reforms will continue

» CJP warns of larger nationwide protest if no decision emerges soon

Ravneet Singh Bittu quits Union ministry, shifts focus to Punjab

SWATI MAHAJAN



CHANDIGARH: Union Minister of State for Railways and Food Processing Industries Ravneet Singh Bittu resigned from the Union Council of Ministers on Friday, with President Droupadi Murmu accepting his resignation on the advice of Prime Minister Narendra Modi with immediate effect. The BJP leader said he will now devote his full attention to Punjab, where Assembly elections are due early next year, as the party prepares to contest the polls independently and push for its first government in the state.

Bittu said he had submitted his resignation on June 21 after his Rajya Sabha term ended and had requested Prime Minister Narendra Modi during his recent visit to Jalandhar, and again earlier this week, to accept it.

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US slaps 10% tariff on goods imported from India over forced labour concerns

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The United States has imposed a 10 per cent tariff on goods imported from India and 16 other countries under a broader move targeting products linked to forced labour. The decision came after India amended its foreign trade policy to ban the import of goods produced using forced labour.

The revised tariff is lower than the 12.5 per cent duty proposed for India on June 3 under Section 301 of the Trade Act. Washington acknowledged New Delhi's policy change, introduced on July 14, while finalising the tariff rates.

In a memorandum issued on Thursday, US President Donald Trump said, "As a result of these actions, the Trade Representative has advised me that the goods of these economies should be tariffed at the 10 per cent rate to further encourage these economies to effectively enforce such prohibitions."

US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer announced tariffs on 60

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Black Sea: Indian killed in attack on commercial vessel

NEW DELHI: An Indian sailor was killed after the MV OMORFI came under attack in the Black Sea on July 18, reportedly in Russian waters, the MEA said Friday. Two other Indians aboard were safe. India condemned attacks on commercial shipping and urged protection of maritime navigation and global commerce.

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CJI rejects 'reckless' reports on denying NEET protest hearing, SC to take up pleas on July 27

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court found itself at the centre of a NEET-related controversy on Friday, as Chief Justice Surya Kant rejected claims that he had refused to hear a plea on police action against protesting students, even as his bench agreed, in the same sitting, to take up two petitions on the issue next week. A separate bench, meanwhile, pressed the Centre on broader paper-leak reforms.

While lawyers mentioned the

matter for urgent listing, the Chief Justice clarified that no writ petition had been filed when the issue was first raised earlier this week. He said only a representation had been sent to the court.

"In the last two days, a completely false statement was made that a matter was filed, and the media is absolutely free from all responsibility and falsely reporting that the Chief Justice refused to list the matter," he said. "Till morning 10 am, not a single page has been filed. It was one representation. How can I treat the rep-

The petitions relate to allegations of police excesses during protests against the NEET paper leak, including the July 20 Cockroach Janta Party-led march in Delhi

resentation as a writ petition?"

Senior advocate Gopal San-karanarayanan later informed a bench headed by the Chief Justice that two separate petitions had now been filed and num-

bered by the Supreme Court registry. He urged an early hearing, saying, "Police is using excessive force against the students. The court stands between us and the police." The bench, also comprising Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana, agreed to hear the pleas on July 27.

The petitions relate to allegations of police excesses during protests against the NEET paper leak, including the July 20 Cockroach Janta Party-led march in Delhi. The protest turned violent after

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Govt orders GitHub to remove Bluetooth-based chat app Bitchat over security issue

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Indian Cybercrime Coordination Centre (I4C), the cybercrime wing under the Union Home Ministry, has directed Microsoft-owned GitHub to remove the Bluetooth-based messaging application Bitchat, saying the platform poses a threat to national security and could be misused for unlawful activities.

According to a notice dated July 23, I4C said Bitchat allows decentralised peer-to-peer messaging over Bluetooth mesh networks without relying on mobile networks, internet connectivity or centralised servers. It said such technology enables communication even during network restrictions, making lawful interception and investigation difficult for

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Himachal: Falling boulders crush moving car, 13 dead



Wreckage of a vehicle after boulders fell on it from a hillside in the Pangti valley, Chamba district, Himachal Pradesh, Friday

MPOST BUREAU

SHIMLA: Thirteen people, including a six-month-old infant, were killed after massive boulders crashed onto a moving taxi on the Udaipur-Killar road in Himachal Pradesh's Lahaul and Spiti district on Friday. Two passengers survived by jumping out of the vehicle moments before it was

struck, police said.

The sport utility vehicle was carrying 15 people from Kullu to Killar when rocks suddenly fell from a nearby hill near Kadu nallah, close to the border of Lahaul-Spiti and Chamba districts. The impact completely crushed the vehicle, and its rear section caught fire.

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SC bars posting, uploading court proceedings on social media without prior permission

Says judicial proceedings cannot become a '24x7 entertainment channel'

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Friday passed an interim order barring the extraction, editing, sharing, reposting or monetisation of audio and video recordings of court proceedings on social media and other digital platforms without prior approval from the court administration, saying judicial hearings cannot become a "24x7 entertainment channel".

A bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana issued the direction while agreeing to hear a petition filed by journalist Harshita Grover, which seeks to stop the unauthorised extraction, modification, dissemination and commercial

HIGHLIGHTS

» Interim order covers extraction, editing, posting, reposting and monetisation of recordings

» Prior approval from court authorities is now mandatory

» Order applies to Supreme Court and High Court proceedings

» News reporting of court proceedings remains unaffected

» Court issued notices to Centre and social media platforms

use of recordings of judicial proceedings.

"As an interim measure, it is directed that there shall be no extraction, modification, dissemination, monetisation, posting, reposting and uploading of audio-video recordings of judicial proceedings on social media or other digital platforms without prior permission of the secretary general of this court

or the registrar general of the jurisdictional high courts," the bench said.

The court clarified that the order would not affect news reporting of court proceedings. It also issued notices to the Centre, several social media platforms and other respondents, seeking their replies to the petition.

Appearing for the petitioner, senior advocate Vikas

Singh said edited and selective clips of hearings were increasingly being circulated online, often stripping proceedings of their context. He cited a July 10 incident in which a litigant appearing in person allegedly abused the court and threw legal papers during a hearing, saying the video was widely shared on social media and turned into a subject of ridicule.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta supported the plea, saying snippets of hearings were being used to create misleading narratives. He also warned that artificial intelligence and other digital tools could manipulate videos by altering the words spoken by judges or lawyers.

The Chief Justice said he had

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PM Modi thanks people for responses, positive suggestions

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday thanked everyone for the responses and positive suggestions received to his video, where he announced the government's decision to bring a strict law to punish those involved in paper leaks.

"Thank you, friends. I got the opportunity to talk to you at midnight. The way you have responded to my video, positive suggestions given by you, thanks



to everybody. Your love will continue to flow; our relations will continue with more bonding. Thank you, thank you friends," he said in the fresh video message released through his Instagram handle.

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OPPOSITION STEPS UP HEAT ON CENTRE

Rahul shows evidence of pellet injuries, slams govt



Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi along with a victim of alleged pellet gun firing during a students protest march carried out by Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) on 20th July, interacts with media, in New Delhi

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Friday intensified the opposition's attack on the Centre over the alleged use of force against students protesting exam paper leaks, demanding the removal of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, action against security personnel accused of attacking demonstrators, and an apology from Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Gandhi made the demands

while presenting an injured protester before the media, as more accounts emerged from people hurt during the July 20 "Sansad Chalo" march in Delhi, where protesters alleged pellet gun injuries despite police denying their use.

Addressing reporters outside Congress Parliamentary Party chief Sonia Gandhi's residence, Gandhi stood beside Sahil, a student who said he was hit in the face during the protest. Showing

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HOME GUARDS REMOVES HIM

Authorities reject man’s claim he left Delhi Police in support of CJP

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Videos surfaced on social media on Friday showing a man asserting he resigned from the Delhi Police as a constable in support of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) protest at Jantar Mantar, a claim authorities rejected.

The Directorate General Home Guards, Delhi government, said in an X post that the individual posting reels/videos on Instagram as Ravi Lovey has been identified as Ravi Kumar. “He is not a Delhi Police constable and has no association with the Delhi Police,” the directorate said.

In a viral video, the individual claimed that he is a Delhi Police jawan holding a good position.

“The day I got to know that the protest would take place, I went on medical leave. I got



People participate in a protest against the alleged NEET-UG paper leak and, examination irregularities at Jantar Mantar, on Friday

a call again that my leave was finished. I want to extend my medical leave. The Delhi Police denied extending my medical leave,” he can be heard saying.

He alleged that the police force “pressurised him” to join the force and he resigned.

“Quarter nahi chahiye, sarkari gadi nahi chahiye, sarkari salary nahi chahiye” (I don’t want a quarter, government vehicle or government’s salary),” he said.

According to the DG Home Guards, Ravi Kumar was serving as a volunteer with the Delhi Home Guards, which functions under the Directorate General of Home Guards, a separate organisation from the Delhi Police.

“In view of his misconduct, he has been discharged from the Delhi Home Guards with immediate effect,” it said.

The views expressed by him are personal, made in his

“The CJP-led agitation began on June 20 at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi and is demanding accountability over alleged irregularities in competitive exams”

individual capacity, and do not represent the views of the Delhi Home Guards, the Delhi Police or any Government agency, it said.

The CJP-led agitation began on June 20 at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi and is demanding accountability over alleged irregularities in competitive examinations, reforms in the education system and the resignation of education minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

Delhi Police suspends leaves of all personnel

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police has cancelled all routine leave for its personnel with immediate effect amid the prevailing law and order situation in the capital, police sources said on Friday.

According to an order issued by the police headquarters, casual and earned leave will remain suspended until further orders, with only genuine emergency leave to be granted after due verification and approval. The directive has been circulated to all district Deputy Commissioners of Police and other senior officers.

Delhi Police deny role in pellet gun incident

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police on Thursday denied any involvement in the alleged use of pellet guns during the Cockroach Janta Party’s (CJP) protest over the alleged NEET paper leak, stating that the Rapid Action Force (RAF) deployed at the site operates under the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF), not the Delhi Police.

Responding to allegations that a 19-year-old protester was injured by a pellet gun during the July 20 demonstration near Jantar Mantar, Delhi Police said it was not the appropriate authority to answer questions on the matter. “RAF is under the CRPF and not Delhi Police. Delhi Police does not have pellet guns,” a police spokesperson said.

The clarification came after reports that a 19-year-old protester was treated at Safdarjung Hospital for suspected pellet injuries. According to the hospital’s case sheet dated July 20, the patient sustained injuries to the right elbow and back, with



‘RAF is under the CRPF and not Delhi Police. Delhi Police does not have pellet guns’: Spokesperson

pellets embedded in the skin.

Media reports, citing sources, also claimed that several protesters were injured in the alleged use of pellet guns during the demonstration, prompting demands for an independent inquiry. The CRPF, which oversees the RAF, has not commented on the allegations. Pellet guns are standard riot-control equipment with the RAF and have previ-

ously been used by the CRPF during law-and-order operations in Jammu and Kashmir. Under standard operating procedures, they are to be fired from a distance and aimed below the waist to minimise the risk of serious injury.

The allegations triggered sharp political reactions.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi, in a televised address on Thursday, announced that the Centre would introduce a Bill in Parliament next week to strengthen action against paper leaks.

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge demanded that the Prime Minister apologise to students and take action against those responsible for the alleged use of force.

Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi, after visiting injured protesters, alleged that security forces had used excessive force against unarmed students. He claimed that one protester had suffered an eye injury after being hit by a pellet and called the incident a grave betrayal of public trust.

Public urged to avoid restricted areas as police issue advisory

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Traffic Police on Friday issued a traffic advisory asking the public to avoid travelling to areas under prohibitory orders unless absolutely necessary and advised app-based mobility, food delivery and e-commerce platforms to regulate their operations in the notified zones.

The advisory comes in view of ongoing Cockroach Janta Party protests in Delhi. Authorities have imposed prohibitory orders under Section 163 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), 2023, in key parts of the capital to maintain public order.

Police said ride-hailing platforms, food delivery services, quick-commerce operators, logistics providers and other e-commerce entities should take note of the restrictions while operating their digital platforms in the affected areas.

The advisory said the companies may adopt measures such as temporary geo-fencing of the restricted locations or suspension of ride and delivery services to and from the notified areas, wherever operationally feasible.

The police said the measures are intended to safeguard drivers, riders, delivery partners and the general public while minimising movement into the restricted zones.

Members of the public have also been advised to



avoid unnecessary travel to the affected areas, cooperate with police personnel and follow lawful directions issued on the ground. Citizens were urged to plan their journeys in advance and use alternate routes wherever possible.

Emergency services, including ambulances, fire services, authorised government vehicles and other exempted categories, will continue to operate as permitted, the advisory said.

Delhi Police also appealed to citizens not to circulate rumours or unverified information and to rely only on official advisories. It urged all stakeholders, including digital service providers, to extend full cooperation in maintaining law and order until the prohibitory orders remain in force.

Motorists have been requested to remain patient, follow traffic rules and comply with directions issued by traffic personnel deployed at key intersections. Moreover, citizens have been asked to contact the Delhi Police helpline in case of any emergency or assistance.

Police sets up STF to probe public exam offences

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police has constituted a Special Task Force (STF) within its Crime Branch to investigate paper leaks and other exam-related offences, according to an official order.

The move has been approved under the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act by the police commissioner.

According to a Delhi Police statement, the measure is aimed at ensuring prompt, professional and comprehensive investigation into offences involving recruitment and entrance examinations conducted by various central agencies.

According to the order, the STF will have the remit to probe offences committed in exams conducted by the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC), Staff Selection Commission (SSC), Railway Recruitment Boards (RRBs), Institute of Banking Personnel Selection (IBPS), National Testing Agency (NTA), and recruitment tests by ministries, departments and their attached and subordinate offices of the central government.

The unit will also handle cases involving any other authority notified by the central government from time to time.

The STF has also been tasked with coordinating closely with prosecuting agencies to ensure speedy prosecution and facilitate day-to-day trial of cases arising under the Act, the order said.

The force will be headed by the Crime Branch deputy commissioner. Overall supervision and administrative control of the unit will rest with the Crime Branch special commissioner.

Videos, call records, social media posts made during July 20 violence under police scanner



NEW DELHI: Delhi Police is examining thousands of videos, social media broadcasts and mobile phone records to identify those involved in the July 20 clashes and establish whether the July 20 violence was pre-planned or erupted spontaneously, sources said on Friday.

Experts are analysing mobile phone recordings, CCTV footage, livestreams and social media content to identify individuals seen attacking police personnel and damaging public property, they said.

“Teams will investigate videos uploaded on various social media platforms, besides content circulated on messaging application groups,” a police source said. The police are trying to match faces, clothing,

movements and locations with surveillance footage and photographs captured during the violence.

“Every digital file is being authenticated to establish its originality and timeline before it can be used as evidence. Metadata, timestamps and geolocation details embedded in videos and photographs are also being examined wherever available,” the source said. The member of the force said investigators are also identifying people who went live on social media during the protests, believing such broadcasts could provide an uninterrupted sequence of events and reveal the presence of individuals who later participated in violence.

The police are exploring whether data preservation requests need to be

issued to major social media platforms to ensure that livestreams, deleted videos, and user account information relevant to the investigation are not lost before legal requests are processed.

Investigators have started analysing Call Detail Records (CDRs), mobile tower locations and communication patterns of several suspects to determine whether protesters coordinated before trying to breach police barricades. Police are analysing mobile tower data to reconstruct suspects’ movements during the July 20 clashes. They also identified over 480 Pakistan-based social media handles allegedly spreading misinformation on the protests and initiated action to block them.

Film City sit-in called off

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: A proposed Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) demonstration outside media offices in Noida’s Film City was called off on Thursday after one of the organisers reportedly received a call from Delhi Police

“Demonstration outside media offices in Film City was called off after one of the organisers reportedly received a call from Delhi Police”

of Mayur Vihar police station, denied any attempt to stop the protest, saying police had merely sought to verify information circulating on social media.

A video of the conversation has surfaced online. While police described it as a routine enquiry, CJP members maintained that the call led to the protest being cancelled.

Cops recover jewellery meant for 6-year-old’s spine surgery

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A crestfallen family got its smile back after the Delhi Police solved a theft case and recovered Rs 12.5 lakh worth of gold and silver jewellery that had been saved for their six-year-old daughter’s spine surgery at AIIMS here.

Police said they recovered the Rs 12.5 lakh haul and arrested the alleged burglar on Friday. The officer said the family was devastated after burglars stole the jewellery they had saved by selling their valuables, and it was their only hope for their child’s treatment; consequently, the family was contemplating mortgaging their house to continue treatment.

“The family had sold their valuables and pooled together their lifetime savings to raise the money for the surgery. And after the theft, they had begun consider-

ing mortgaging their house to continue the treatment,” a senior police officer said.

Police said the case was reported at the Keshav Puram police station on July 22 after burglars allegedly broke a window pane of the family’s house in the Ganeshpura area and fled with gold and silver jewellery valued at around Rs 12.5 lakh.

Given the circumstances, senior officers directed that the investigation take priority. A special police team used technical evidence to trace and arrest Abhishek alias Rajee (25), a Wazirpur resident with two previous burglary cases, within six hours.

Based on his disclosure, officers recovered the stolen jewellery and returned it to the family, enabling their six-year-old daughter’s spine treatment to continue. Further investigation is underway.

RAF launches inquiry into actions of its personnel during Delhi student protest

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Rapid Action Force (RAF) has initiated an inquiry into allegations of its personnel using disproportionate force and firing pellet guns during the ongoing student protests in Delhi, officials said on Friday.

The officials stated that the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) has asked the inspector general (IG) of the RAF, its special anti-riots unit, to verify the sequence of events its various teams undertook to “control” the protesters as well as incidents where they were attacked.

CRPF officials said a formal Court of Inquiry (CoI) has not been initiated into these incidents yet. They said such a probe will be ordered once this verification exercise reveals the facts.

The students launched a ‘Chalo Sansad’ march from their ‘dharna’ site at Jantar Mantar on July 20 under the umbrella of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) demanding



that Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan resign and take responsibility for the recent NEET question paper leak.

The officials said the RAF has taken cognisance of multiple social media videos and photos featuring its personnel in blue dungarees. They include footage showing them deploying guns and sticks and undertaking a lathi-charge, alongside videos where its personnel were surrounded and attacked by the crowd.

“All legal procedures stipulated to check the conduct

of the personnel during such operational duties will be followed,” a senior officer of the force said.

The officials said the RAF possesses the 12-bore pump-action gun, also known as a pellet gun, as part of its riot control armoury. The standard operating procedure (SOP) stipulates use of the pellet gun when jawans face extremely challenging situations, including a grave danger to their life, they said.

According to the SOP, these guns should essentially be used with a deflector so that the

metal or rubber pellet inflicts fewer injuries and only on the lower half of the body.

At least two students have been admitted to local hospitals with pellet injuries since January 20.

While the Delhi Police has said it does not possess pellet guns and called such reports misleading, neither the CRPF nor the RAF has commented on the charges of their personnel firing the ammunition so far. The RAF is also verifying instances where footage shows stranded jawans being attacked by protesters, a video where a man in an RAF uniform was depicted tripping a rushing protester (causing the protester to fall), and another where a shock-emitting gun was stated to be used against a protester.

The CRPF has barred RAF and other deployed personnel from speaking to the media and is examining a woman RAF officer’s reported Instagram comments on the protests for possible violation of its 2023 social media policy.

Student protest broadens into multi-generational movement

SENIOR CITIZENS BACK EDU REFORMS

NEW DELHI: As the protest over paper leak at Jantar Mantar entered its seventh week on Friday, the movement that began with students is increasingly drawing support from an unlikely quarter -- senior citizens, who say they have joined the agitation because the issue concerns the future of the country’s youth.

Amid hundreds of Gen Z protesters camping at the site, people in their 50s, 60s and even 70s were seen sitting alongside students, raising slogans, attending meetings and lending support to the demand for reforms in public examinations.

Dev Nath Maurya, a 64-year-old farmer from Uttar Pradesh’s Raebareilly, said he travelled for nearly 12 hours with a group of around 30 people to reach the national capital.

“We have not come here for today; we have come here for this country’s future. These young kids are our future. What face will I show to my grandchildren when they ask what I



was doing while the young ones were trying to bring education reforms?” Maurya said.

Ram Avtaar, also in his 60s, said the news of rising number of student suicides across the country had compelled him to join the protest.

“I have not studied much, but I know that education is one of the most, if not the most important thing in life. Around 20 students have died; tomorrow this figure can increase significantly. Who will be responsible?” he asked.

The protest at Jantar Mantar began on early June under the banner of the Cockroach

Janta Party (CJP), along with several student organisations. The protesters have been demanding the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over the alleged NEET-UG 2026 paper leak and irregularities in the CBSE’s on-screen marking process, besides seeking wider reforms in the conduct of public examinations.

The agitation gathered wider attention after activist Sonam Wangchuk joined it with an indefinite hunger strike on June 28 and following clashes between police and protesters on July 20.

Om Prasad, 58, who travelled from Madhya Pradesh, said the movement reminded him of some of the country’s major public agitations.

Senior citizens and BKU (Khosla) members joined the agitation, boosting students’ morale. Protesters said the movement had evolved into an inter-generational campaign for education reforms, uniting people across age groups.

Passenger held with 19.5 kg of hydroponic weed

NEW DELHI: Customs officials at Delhi’s Indira Gandhi International Airport have seized 19.5 kg of suspected hydroponic weed from a passenger arriving from Bangkok and arrested him under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act.

The passenger, who landed on July 22, was intercepted by the Air Intelligence Unit after crossing the green channel on the basis of Advance Passenger Information System profiling.

An X-ray scan of the baggage revealed suspicious images. On examination, officials recovered five vacuum-sealed packets containing a green substance suspected to be hydroponic weed, weighing 19.595 kg, including the packaging.

The suspected contraband, along with the concealment and packing material, was seized under the NDPS Act. The passenger was arrested, and further investigation is underway to ascertain the source and intended destination of the consignment.

CM REKHA PROMISES 24X7 MEDICAL CARE, SANITATION AND SECURITY

Capital ready for Kanwar Yatra

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: With the annual Kanwar Yatra set to witness the arrival of lakhs of devotees in the national capital, the Delhi government on Friday finalised an extensive plan to ensure smooth movement, security and civic facilities for Kanwariyas. Chairing a high-level review meeting at the Delhi Secretariat, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta directed officials to make comprehensive arrangements, including round-the-clock sanitation, medical care, uninterrupted power and water supply, improved mobile toilets and coordinated traffic management across the city.

Calling the pilgrimage a symbol of India's cultural ethos, Gupta said, "The Kanwar Yatra is a message of service, devotion, social harmony and cultural unity." She added that during the holy month of Shravan, "Lakhs of devotees of Lord Shiva pass through Delhi chanting 'Har Har Mahadev' and 'Bol Bam', filling the entire atmosphere with faith and devotion."

The Chief Minister said the



government has ensured that every Kanwariya entering Delhi is welcomed with dignity and provided necessary facilities. "The Delhi government has made comprehensive arrangements to ensure that every Kanwariya entering the Capital is welcomed with respect, provided security and offered better facilities," she said.

The meeting was attended by

Delhi's Minister for Art and Culture and Chairman of the Kanwar Committee Kapil Mishra, committee member MLAs Ajay Mahawar, Anil Sharma, Karnail Singh, Sanjay Goyal and Umang Bajaj, along with senior officials from multiple departments.

As part of the preparations, welcome gates will be installed at key entry points into Delhi, while devotees will also be

greeted with flower showers. Gupta said she would personally visit different parts of the city to welcome the Kanwariyas. "The people of Delhi have always shown deep faith and a strong spirit of service towards devotees of Lord Shiva. This year too, the government and the public will come together to make the Kanwar Yatra a memorable occasion marked

“The Delhi govt has made comprehensive arrangements to ensure that every Kanwariya entering the Capital is welcomed with respect, provided security and offered better facilities

— CM REKHA GUPTA

by devotion, service and hospitality," she said.

To streamline administrative processes, the government has introduced a single-window system for Kanwar committees to obtain permissions and access various civic services without approaching multiple departments.

The Chief Minister directed officials to accord top priority to sanitation at Kanwar camps, ensuring round-the-clock cleaning and adequate deployment of sanitation workers. She also ordered an increase in the number of mobile toilets while stressing their quality, regular maintenance and accountability. "Negligence at any level will not be tolerated," she warned.

The Health Department

has been instructed to deploy doctors and healthcare staff in shifts to provide 24-hour medical assistance at camps. Officials were also directed to ensure adequate drinking water, uninterrupted electricity supply and advance measures to tackle waterlogging during the monsoon.

Traffic and security arrangements were also reviewed. Gupta instructed officials to complete barricading, route diversions, PCR deployment and accident-prevention measures in coordination with the Delhi Police and Traffic Police. She emphasised that traffic management should allow the Kanwar Yatra to proceed smoothly while minimising inconvenience to commuters.



Ghazipur: High-tech desilting drive begins

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Aiming to strengthen Delhi's flood management system ahead of the monsoon, the Delhi government on Friday deployed two advanced long-boom amphibious excavators to begin large-scale desilting of the Ghazipur Drain, one of the Capital's key drainage channels. The machines were inaugurated by Irrigation and Flood Control Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh, who said the initiative marks the start of technology-driven restoration of drains that have remained heavily silted for decades.

The Ghazipur Drain carries stormwater from Noida, Sahibabad, Chilla and surrounding industrial areas before entering Delhi, making it crucial for the city's drainage network. According to officials, years of accumulated silt have significantly reduced the drain's carrying capacity, increasing the risk of waterlogging during heavy rainfall.

Addressing the gathering, Singh said, "This drain has not seen proper desilting for nearly 30 to 40 years. Massive quantities of silt have accumulated over time, severely reducing its carrying capacity. Our government's first priority is to remove this legacy silt and restore every major drain so that Delhi is better prepared during the monsoon." He added that similar machines would be deployed across other major drains under the Irrigation and Flood Control Department to speed up desilting operations and improve flood preparedness across the city.

Unlike conventional excavators, the newly inducted amphibious machines are designed to work on dry land, marshy terrain, shallow water and directly inside drains. Their specialised design allows them to access areas that were previously difficult or impossible to reach using standard equipment.

Each excavator is equipped with a 15-metre long boom, can excavate up to a depth of nine metres and features a 0.50 cubic metre bucket powered by a 140 HP engine. The machines are capable of removing deep deposits of silt, sludge, garbage, debris and aquatic vegetation, including water hyacinth, without requiring temporary working platforms or extensive manual labour.

Officials said the ability of the excavators to move seamlessly between land and water would reduce operational delays and significantly improve the speed and efficiency of desilting work.

The Delhi government has procured the machines at a cost of Rs 2.62 crore each as part of its broader push to modernise drainage infrastructure.

Officials of the Irrigation and Flood Control Department said the deployment would help restore the carrying capacity of major drains, reduce waterlogging during intense rainfall and improve Delhi's overall flood management system. They added that the initiative forms part of the government's long-term strategy to clear decades of accumulated silt and ensure critical drainage channels function at their designed capacity.

Sirsa: 15L plants for Delhi Ridge

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Environment Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa on Friday joined senior government officials in a plantation drive at the Ridge and said 15 lakh trees and saplings are being planted across the Ridge and other identified green areas.

He reiterated the government's target of planting 70 lakh trees and saplings across the national capital this year.

Chief Secretary Rajeev Verma, along with senior officials of the Delhi government, participated in the plantation drive held at the PBG Ground under the government's ongoing green campaign.

Addressing the gathering, Sirsa said the campaign is inspired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi's "Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam" initiative and aims to expand Delhi's green cover through large-scale public participation.

He said 15 lakh trees and saplings are being planted across the Ridge and other identified green areas as part of a comprehensive eco-restoration programme.

The minister said every sapling planted under the campaign is being geo-tagged to enable scientific monitoring and ensure its long-term survival.

"The objective is not merely to increase plantation numbers but to create a sustainable green legacy for future generations," he said.

Sirsa said the Delhi government has prepared a



10-year plantation strategy focused on increasing the capital's green cover through native species that require less water, provide greater shade, generate more oxygen and help reduce pollution.

He said the plantation drive has drawn participation from members of the judiciary, government officials, diplomats from over 70 countries, educational institutions, religious organisations and citizen groups, reflecting the government's effort to make environmental conservation a people's movement.

Highlighting the government's parallel drive to eliminate Delhi's legacy waste, Sirsa claimed that nearly 60 per cent of the city's garbage mountains have been cleared over the last one-and-a-half years.

He said the reclaimed land is being converted into green spaces through plantation and ecological restoration, adding that the twin initiatives of waste remediation and large-scale plantation are aimed at building a cleaner, greener and healthier capital.

Cloudy skies, light rain keep mercury in check in Delhi

NEW DELHI: Delhi remained under generally cloudy skies with spells of light rain and drizzle on Friday, keeping the mercury in check as the maximum temperature settled at 34.6 degrees Celsius, slightly below normal. The maximum temperature in Delhi-NCR ranged between 32.9 and 34.6 degrees Celsius. Station-wise data showed Palam recording 32.9 degrees Celsius, two degrees below normal, while Lodhi Road, Ridge and Ayanagar recorded 33.3 degrees Celsius each, 0.7, 0.9 and 1.7 degrees below normal, respectively.

The India Meteorological Department has forecast generally cloudy skies with light rain or drizzle on Saturday. Strong surface winds along with very light to light rainfall are likely during the forenoon and afternoon, while very light to light rain is expected during the evening and night. Delhi received 0.5 mm rainfall in the 24 hours ending at 8.30 am on Friday. Palam, Lodhi Road, Ridge and Ayanagar recorded 0.6 mm, 0.8 mm, 3.6 mm and nil rainfall, respectively. Between 8.30 am and 5.30 pm, Safdarjung recorded 0.6 mm rainfall, Palam 3.3 mm, Lodhi Road 0.5 mm, Ridge trace rainfall and Ayanagar 0.3 mm. The minimum temperature across the city ranged between 23.1 and 27.3 degrees Celsius. Safdarjung recorded 27.3 degrees Celsius, normal for the season, while Palam, Lodhi Road, Ridge and Ayanagar recorded 25, 26.8, 23.1 and 26.8 degrees Celsius, respectively.

MP0ST

FRS: 'Security, not surveillance'

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: Facial Recognition System (FRS) cameras have been installed at various places around Jantar Mantar as a security measure and not to keep watch on protesters, Delhi Police sources said on Friday.

The decision to install them was taken "in view of the law and order situation in New Delhi" and to prevent anti-social elements, wanted criminals, and other miscreants from taking advantage of the protests and wreaking havoc, police sources said. Delhi Police sources said the claims that the FRS cameras had been installed to keep watch on the demonstrators were "misleading and incorrect".

They said that the use of FRS cameras was "a normal security measure" which was taken during large gatherings and festivals in the national capital. Police sources said that FRS cameras had been used during Republic Day, Independence Day, Holi, Diwali, Eid, and Ramlila celebrations.



They said that the intelligence received by Delhi Police and the central agencies was that "elements across the border were watching the student protests with interest".

These "anti-social elements" were trying to take advantage of the situation to "create mischief", police sources claimed. "In view of the intelligence inputs, Delhi Police has beefed up security around Jantar Mantar to ensure that the protests remain peaceful and that wanted criminals and anti-social elements are kept away from the protest sites," sources said. They also said that the installation of FRS cameras was to aid in maintaining law and order and not to "spy on the protesters".

'No ban on food delivery services'

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police on Friday dismissed as "false, baseless and misleading" social media claims that food delivery app services have been banned across the New Delhi area. In a clarification, police said no such restriction has been imposed and urged citizens not to believe or share unverified information circulating on social media. People have been advised to rely only on official sources for authentic updates, police said. MP0ST

Two Metro stations reopen, 15 still shut

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

NEW DELHI: Entry gates at Mandi House and Central Secretariat Metro stations were reopened on Friday evening, but 15 other stations in central Delhi continued to remain closed for the third consecutive day over security concerns amid the ongoing Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) protest near Jantar Mantar.

On Friday morning, the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) announced that 17 stations — Lok Kalyan Marg, Rajiv Chowk, Patel Chowk,



Ramakrishna Ashram Marg, Barakhamba Road, Supreme Court, Seva Teerth, Janpath, Mandi House, Central Secretariat, ITO, Delhi Gate, Indraprastha, Khan Market, Jor Bagh, Shivaji Stadium and Jhandewalan — would remain closed

from 7.30 am until further orders. Hours later, the 18th — the New Delhi metro station — was also closed.

At Janpath metro station, the closest station to the protest site at Jantar Mantar, glass panels at the entry were covered with

newspapers by CISF personnel as protesters had drawn graffiti across parts of the protest venue.

The interchange facility continued to remain available at Rajiv Chowk, Mandi House and Central Secretariat stations, the DMRC said. The 17 stations had remained shut on Wednesday and Thursday as well.

While entry gates at Rajiv Chowk, Mandi House and Central Secretariat were reopened late on Thursday after remaining closed for around 14 hours, they were shut again from Friday morning.

Later in the day on Friday,

entry gates at Mandi House and Central Secretariat were reopened, while the remaining 15 stations continued to remain closed. The prolonged closure of metro stations has disrupted travel for office-goers, students and lawyers, with commuters in central Delhi continuing to face delays and being forced to rely on road transport.

On Wednesday, the Supreme Court Bar Association moved the apex court, saying the closure of several metro stations had made it difficult for lawyers and litigants to reach the Supreme Court.

4 senior IAS Officers named SIR observers

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi poll body has appointed four senior IAS officers as observers to oversee the upcoming objection and claims phase and preparation of final electoral rolls under the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise, officials said on Friday.

According to a Delhi Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) office document, IAS officers of the Delhi government, Pandurang Pole, Rashmi Singh, Yashpal Garg and K Mahesh have been appointed observers for SIR in different districts.

While Pole is observer of North West, West and South West districts, Singh is observer of South East, South and New Delhi districts, and Garg of Central North, North, Outer North, Old Delhi and North districts.

Mahesh has been appointed observer of North East, East and Central districts.

Currently, door-to-door exercise for filling up

of enumeration forms is underway.

The Booth Level Officers (BLOs) have so far distributed enumeration forms to almost all the 1.45 crore voters and digitised around 40 percent of the filled forms.

The observers will undertake visits in the districts assigned to them, first during the period of receipt of claims and objections from voters from August 17 to September 16. The second round of visits will commence from September 17 to October 15 when claims and objections will be disposed of by the poll officials.

They will also make visits at the time of verification of the working copy by the BLOs, and final publication of electoral rolls on October 19.

An officer of Delhi CEO office said the observers were part of the exercise to ensure that the entire SIR exercise is completed with transparency and genuine concerns of the voters are adequately addressed.

NDMC Chairman transferred to Secy Ministry of Mines

NEW DELHI: New Delhi Municipal Council Chairperson Keshav Chandra was transferred on Thursday and appointed Secretary in the Ministry of Mines as part of a major bureaucratic reshuffle approved by the Appointments Committee of the Cabinet (ACC).

Chandra, a 1996-batch AGMUT cadre IAS officer, will succeed Piyush Goyal, who has been appointed Secretary General of the National Human Rights Commission (NHRC), according to an official order.

Chandra was appointed NDMC chairperson in October 2024. Before that, he served as the Chief Secretary of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands and has held several key positions in the Delhi government, including Chief Executive Officer of the Delhi Jal Board, Secretary (Environment) and Chief Electoral Officer.

The appointments were part of a wider reshuffle in the senior bureaucracy approved by the ACC. AGENCIES

TEACHERS, JNUSU QUESTION ADVISORIES

After Delhi University, JNU & JMI ask students to stay away from protests

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: After Delhi University colleges, Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU) on Friday warned students and faculty of legal consequences and asked them to stay away from the ongoing Jantar Mantar protest, while Jamia Millia Islamia (JMI) issued an appeal urging students to refrain from activities that could jeopardise their academic future.

Meanwhile, Opposition leaders have criticised the universities for issuing such advisories, with Lok Sabha Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi slamming Delhi University.

In a post on X (formerly Twitter), Gandhi wrote, "How dare you threaten students for exercising their democratic rights?" "Please note, you are the ones that will be held accountable when the time comes," the post added.

Earlier in the day on Friday, JNU advised students, faculty and staff to refrain from participating in or visiting gatherings at or around Jantar Mantar, citing the Supreme Court's directions on public demonstrations.

In an advisory posted on X, JNU urged members of its "epistemic community" to prioritise their personal safety and warned that irresponsible social media activity could invite legal consequences and disciplinary action.

JMI, while welcoming students to the new academic session, urged them to focus on studies, underscoring that "nothing is worth placing at risk a future nurtured through such hard work, dedication and sacrifice."

Referring to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's assurance that students' interests would be protected and strict action would be taken against those "who have played with the future of the stu-



dents," the university appealed to students and stakeholders to refrain from any activity that is unlawful. The advisories come amid continuing protests near Jantar Mantar over the alleged NEET-UG 2026 paper leak, which have led to heightened security measures and transport restrictions in central Delhi. The developments also follow

a series of messages issued by Delhi University colleges on the issue.

Aditi Mahavidyalaya had appealed to students to stay away from violence and urged them to express views only through peaceful, democratic and legal means, while Shyam Lal College posted a message expressing support for Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

Earlier, Rajdhani College had withdrawn a similar post from its official social media handle and issued a public apology after it drew criticism from sections of students and teachers. However, similar messages were later shared by other college authorities, including the principal of Shaheed Bhagat Singh College. The posts by Delhi University colleges have drawn criticism from teachers' bodies, which questioned educational institutions taking

public positions on a politically contentious issue. They argued that universities should instead focus on addressing students' concerns over the examination system, paper leak allegations and ongoing academic reforms rather than issuing statements perceived to support one side of the controversy.

The JNU Students' Union (JNUSU) also condemned the university administration's advisory, alleging that the administration was threatening students with legal and disciplinary action merely for exercising their constitutional right to protest. The students' body also alleged that Delhi Police had barricaded all gates of the university, detained several students on their way to Jantar Mantar and harassed a JNU student. It claimed the measures amounted to intimidation and called upon students to join the ongoing protest.

Pradhan’s resignation remains sticking point..

Continued from Page 1

Across more than 150-200 cities had united behind one demand, fixing responsibility at the highest level. He warned that, “if no decision emerged within the next one or two days, CJP would announce another nationwide protest, larger than the Parliament March on July 20.”

Das reiterated that Pradhan’s resignation remained the movement’s “non-negotiable demand.” He said the delegation had also raised concerns over alleged detentions of protesters, lawyers and even food delivery personnel around Jantar Mantar, saying such actions had widened the trust deficit between authorities and students. According to Das, the government initially denied the allegations but later assured the delegation that such incidents, if occurring, would not continue.

CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke said, “the agitation was no longer centred around a handful of individuals but had evolved into a nationwide youth movement.” He asserted that unless Pradhan was removed, the anger among students would only deepen, adding that the campaign would continue with greater intensity.

The talks came hours after climate activist Sonam Wangchuk ended his 26-day fast late Thursday

night at Medanta Hospital in Gurugram. Union Ministers Nadda and Jitendra Singh, along with Wangchuk’s wife Gitanjali Angmo, were present when he broke his fast.

Wangchuk ended the hunger strike after the Centre agreed to engage with the protesters and after Prime Minister Narendra Modi publicly promised stronger action against those involved in paper leak cases.

Earlier on Thursday, the Prime Minister tweeted saying, “the welfare and future of the country’s youth remained the government’s top priority and that those attempting to destroy students’ futures would face stringent punishment.” He also announced measures including fast-track courts for paper leak cases and promised further reforms.

CJP, however, maintained that the announcements did not address the root of the crisis. Das described the proposed fast-track courts as an inadequate response, arguing that merely designating existing courts as fast-track courts would neither reduce pendency nor resolve systemic failures in the examination system. He appealed to students not to mistake temporary administrative measures for structural reform.

Back at Jantar Mantar, the atmosphere remained charged with full determination.

Despite repeated police action, heavy rain, intense humidity, deteriorating health conditions and increasing restrictions around the protest venue, thousands of young protesters continued to stick on the site, raising slogans and doing their bit. Volunteer doctors reported a growing number of cases of dehydration, fever, headaches and sore throats, but said many students refused to leave, insisting they would remain until their demands were met. Additionally, the Delhi Traffic Police advised citizens to avoid the notified area under Section 163 of the BNSS and asked app-based transport, food delivery, logistics and e-commerce platforms to regulate operations in the vicinity.

“The government wants to lay siege to Jantar Mantar. It wants to restrict and stop food delivery, water delivery, sanitation facilities, medical treatment, power lines, and people’s movement to the site. How much lower will they stoop? But remember. It only strengthens the resolve of those who refuse to surrender,” Sausrav Das reacted.

The protest also entered a new phase of controversy after videos surfaced showing AI-enabled facial recognition surveillance vehicles stationed outside Jantar Mantar. The footage appeared to show faces being matched with personal infor-

mation in real time, prompting concerns among protesters. Delhi Police maintained that the system was linked only to its criminal database to identify wanted persons, but many students said the visible surveillance had created an atmosphere of intimidation, with several choosing to cover their faces.

Furthermore, Das also announced that CJP would launch a dedicated website to identify police personnel accused of using excessive force during the Parliament March. He said, “The organisation would seek registration of FIRs against those officers and move the courts if police failed to act.” Rejecting allegations of foreign funding behind the agitation, he questioned why the government would repeatedly engage with CJP and Sonam Wangchuk if those claims were true.

If anything, the uncertainty over the government’s response appeared to have strengthened the resolve of the protesters. With another crucial meeting scheduled for Saturday afternoon, students said they were prepared for a prolonged struggle, maintaining that the campaign had outgrown its organisers and transformed into one of the largest youth-led movements in recent years, one that, they insist, will continue until the government’s accountability is delivered.

HC seeks EC’s stand on PIL challenging deployment of govt school teachers for SIR

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi High Court on Friday sought a response from the Election Commission (EC) on a public interest litigation (PIL) challenging the large-scale deployment of government school teachers as booth level officers (BLOs) and enumeration staff for the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in the national capital.

A bench comprising Chief Justice DK Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia directed the Election Commission to file a short affidavit clarifying its position by Monday. The matter has been listed for further hearing on July 28. The PIL, filed by advocates Rajesh Kumar Gogna and Ashok Agarwal, contends that assigning teachers to election-related duties is adversely affecting classroom teaching and compromising the education of students in government, municipal and government-aided schools.

During the hearing, the court questioned whether government school teachers could be compelled to perform BLO and enumeration duties. The

The PIL contends that assigning teachers to election-related duties is adversely affecting classroom teaching and compromising the education of students

bench observed that if the work was intended to be voluntary, the Commission should state so clearly.

The Election Commission’s counsel submitted that the SIR exercise is being carried out nationwide and that teachers are assigned duties only during non-teaching hours or on holidays. He further informed the court that teachers receive an honorarium for the work and that only a small proportion of teachers are ultimately deployed.

According to the Commission, schools often nominate fewer teachers than initially requested. The EC’s council maintained that the Commission follows a flexible approach while assigning duties and does

not indiscriminately requisition teaching staff. However, the bench expressed concern over making such assignments compulsory. It orally observed that teachers may not wish to undertake additional work despite being offered compensation and emphasised that they also require adequate rest. The court remarked that if the Commission maintained that participation was voluntary, it could dispose of the petition accordingly.

The petitioners argued that the deployment of teachers has resulted in regular classes being handled by guest teachers or educators from unrelated subjects in several schools. They also alleged that the practice violates legal safeguards under the Right to Education Act and runs contrary to an earlier Supreme Court judgment governing the use of teachers for non-educational duties.

The PIL has sought directions to limit the deployment of teachers to 10 per cent of the staff, ensure election duties are assigned only outside teaching hours, and prioritise the use of non-teaching govt personnel for the electoral revision exercise.

From Page 1

NTA officials

The move comes a day after Higher Education Secretary Vineet Joshi was shunted out to the Panchayati Raj Ministry. Outrage surrounding paper leaks and the CBSE digital evaluation glitches has triggered a series of shunting of top officials.

Students’ anger has fanned in the form of a huge protest that is taking place at Jantar Mantar. The protesters and the opposition parties have been demanding Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan’s resignation over the issue.

The NTA has issued advertisements for a set of professional appointments at the level of General Manager and has separately opened the engagement of sixteen Young Professionals through the Pratibha Setu portal of the Union Public Service Commission.

“Further recruitment and empanelment actions across the ten functional verticals recommended by the High-Level Committee of Experts will follow in the coming weeks.

“The measures notified today, together with the Expression of Interest for a fresh empanelment of Subject Matter Experts and Translators issued separately, are part of a systematic strengthening of the academic, operational, technological and integrity capabilities of the NTA,” the official added.

tices in recruitment examinations like UPSC, SSC, etc., and entrance tests such as NEET, JEE, and CUET.

Sources said the amended Bill is likely to come up in Parliament on Monday, as announced by Prime Minister Modi in a video message issued around midnight on Thursday.

In the message, Modi announced that a Bill containing provisions for strong action against paper leaks will be introduced in Parliament next week.

According to the sources, the entire Cabinet is standing behind Pradhan, and the government is unlikely to agree to the opposition’s demand for his resignation.

The opposition is also seeking an apology from the prime minister for the alleged police brutality against the CJP-led protesters, who took out a march to Parliament on July 20 to press their demands.

The sources said the government is also taking up all issues linked to reforms within the National Testing Agency (NTA), which conducts the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (Undergraduate), or NEET-UG, for medical admissions, and is likely to iron them out in a month or two.

“The Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024’ was the first such law brought by the present government in 2024 after a raging debate over paper leaks.

PM Modi

Modi created a new world record with the most views on a reel in 24 hours, garnering 303 million views as of now.

The earlier record was 300 million views.

Modi’s outreach to the youth came four days after the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) took part in the ‘Sansad Chalo’ march to press for their demand for the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over alleged examination-related irregularities.

The Cabinet meeting chaired by PM Modi at the Parliament House complex approved the draft Bill to hand stricter punishments to those involved in paper leaks as compared to the existing law, sources said.

The draft Bill proposes tougher penalties for paper leaks, including a maximum fine of Rs 10 crore and a jail term of up to 10 years, official sources said. The decision came just hours after Prime Minister Narendra Modi announced the government’s plan to introduce stricter provisions.

The Bill will amend ‘The Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024’, proposing a minimum punishment of five years’ imprisonment for individuals involved in paper leaks and/or a fine.

The present law has provisions for three to five years’ imprisonment for individuals, and five to 10 years’ imprisonment and a minimum fine of Rs 1 crore for those involved in the organised crime of cheating and paper leaks.

The Bill is aimed at preventing organised gangs and institutions that indulge in unfair means for monetary gains, while protecting the candidates from its provisions.

The existing law is aimed at curbing leaks, malpractices as well as organised malprac-

demonstrators attempted to march towards Parliament, prompting security personnel to use lathis and tear gas. The protesters were demanding the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

The Delhi High Court had on July 22 sought responses from the Centre and Delhi Police on similar pleas and directed authorities to preserve CCTV footage and other records linked to the police action.

Separately, a bench of Justices P S Narasimha and Alok Aradhe, hearing petitions including one filed by the Federation of All India Medical Association, told the Centre it would closely monitor reforms to stop NEET paper leaks. The court asked the government to place on record the steps taken to improve transparency, implement the recommendations of the seven-member Radhakrishnan Committee and adopt safeguards based on the IIT examination model.

Rahul shows

the injuries, Gandhi claimed the young man’s right eye had been severely damaged.

“My brother was struck by a pellet gun when he was peacefully protesting with a tricolour in hand,” Gandhi said. “This is the future of our country. Thousands of young people have been shot at with pellet guns and beaten in lathi charges while protesting peacefully.”

Calling Pradhan a “criminal education minister” and “a symbol of the collapse of India’s education system,” Gandhi said the minister must be removed for failing to prevent repeated examination paper leaks.

He alleged that Sahil had appeared for a police recruitment examination whose question paper was leaked, saying his family had invested their hard-earned money in preparing him for the opportunity. Gandhi also urged the government to stop “assaulting and threatening” students and said there was uncertainty over whether Sahil’s eyesight could be fully restored.

Later in a social media post, Gandhi identified Sahil as a 19-year-old Delhi University student who also works part-time as a driver to support his family. He said Sahil had joined the protest after allegedly being affected by the 2025 SSC Delhi Constable examination paper leak and was worried because the same vendor had reportedly been selected again. “Education Minister Pradhan must resign,” Gandhi wrote.

Sahil said he was seeking justice after suffering injuries to his right eye. He has already undergone one surgery to remove pellets and repair the damaged eye and is expected to undergo another. He was first admitted to Lady Hardinge Medical College, then shifted to Safdarjung Hospital before being moved to the AIIMS Trauma Centre on July 21.

Speaking later in the Parliament House complex, Gandhi accused the government of refusing to allow him to respond during proceedings after Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju referred to the issue. He claimed his microphone was switched off when he tried to present the opposition’s position.

The Leader of Opposition said the students had three demands: the resignation of Pradhan, action against those responsible for attacking protesters, and an apology from the prime minister. “We are not going to have any conversation, any discussion before Mr Pradhan is sacked,” he said.

The Congress’s stand comes amid a continuing standoff between the opposition and the government over alleged examination paper leaks, the student movement led by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), and the police response to the protests in the national capital.

Meanwhile, more injured protesters described their experiences after the July 20 clashes near Parliament.

Twenty-five-year-old Sheikh Irshad Mansoori, an accounts manager from Gurugram originally from Jabalpur, was dis-

charged from Lady Hardinge Hospital on Friday, four days after surgeons removed pellets lodged in his face and neck.

Recalling the incident, Mansoori said police had started pushing demonstrators back near Connaught Place’s Inner Circle. “We all raised our hands and kept telling them, ‘Sir, please stop. We are not terrorists. We are only protesting,’” he said. Moments later, he felt an object strike his face, with fragments entering different parts of his face and neck.

Doctors told him three pellets had lodged dangerously close to vital structures, including a major nerve, a blood vessel and the muscle controlling movement of his left eye. Emergency surgery was performed the following day. Mansoori said he still has stitches on his neck, inside his eye and inside his mouth, but has regained vision in the affected eye.

Another injured protester, 21-year-old Sakshi, who was hurt in a stampede-like situation near Jantar Mantar and Tolstoy Marg, has been taken off ventilator support at Ram Manohar Lohia Hospital.

The July 20 march formed part of the CJP’s agitation, launched on June 20 at Jantar Mantar, seeking accountability over alleged irregularities in competitive examinations, reforms in the education system and Pradhan’s resignation.

The circumstances surrounding the injuries have also raised questions about the alleged use of pellet guns. Delhi Police has denied that its personnel used pellet guns during the protest, while the CRPF, whose Rapid Action Force was also deployed that day, has not responded to questions on the allegation. According to standard operating procedures, pellet guns fire cartridges containing up to 600 metal or rubber pellets and are required to be fired from a minimum distance of 500 feet, with the muzzle aimed below the waist.

Govt orders GitHub

law enforcement agencies. Sharing a copy of the notice on X on Friday, Bitchat developer and former Twitter CEO Jack Dorsey wrote, “The Government of India does not like technologies like Bitchat and wants it taken down.”

I4C said the application permits anonymous communication without mandatory user registration, phone number verification or centralised logging of messages. It added that the platform’s technical design makes attribution and lawful interception significantly more difficult.

The notice said authorities had identified several applications offering similar decentralised Bluetooth-based communication. It warned that because messages are exchanged directly between nearby devices, such platforms could be used to evade lawful surveillance, coordinate anonymously and bypass restrictions imposed during internet shutdowns or situations involving public disorder, riots, terrorism and organised crime.

According to the notice,

intelligence inputs suggest these platforms could be exploited to organise unlawful assemblies and violent protests, spread misinformation, aid radicalisation, plan criminal conspiracies and undertake activities affecting India’s sovereignty, security, defence and public order.

The action follows reports that participants in a protest organised by the Cockroach Janata Party at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi used Bluetooth-based messaging applications after temporary internet restrictions were imposed around the protest site.

I4C also said the absence of a central service provider limits investigators’ ability to obtain subscriber information, communication records or timely assistance. It told GitHub that Bitchat violates Sections 43, 84B and 84C of the Information Technology Act, along with Section 61 read with Sections 196 and 197. I4C did not immediately respond to a query seeking comment.

‘Beginning of accountability’

According to Wangchuk, the government assured that Parliament would discuss accountability in the “failing” examination system and ways to prevent paper leaks. It also agreed to positively consider compensation for families of students who died by suicide after the NEET-UG paper leak in May and said no cases would be registered against those protesting peacefully at Jantar Mantar or those who joined the July 20 march to Parliament.

Wangchuk ended his fast late on Thursday night at Medanta Hospital in Gurugram in the presence of his wife Gitanjali Angmo, Health Minister J P Nadda and Union minister Jitendra Singh.

Ravneet Singh

“I told the PM saab during the Jalandhar rally and also on Monday that it is my request that my resignation be accepted and give your blessings,” Bittu said.

In a post on X, Bittu thanked President Murmu and Prime Minister Modi for giving him the opportunity to serve in the Union government. “It has been an honour to serve the people of India, especially my beloved Punjab,” he said, adding that his public service would continue “with renewed dedication.”

A prominent Sikh face of the BJP, Bittu is expected to contest the Assembly elections, with Ludhiana being seen as a likely constituency. In June, he had said he wanted to work in the Punjab Vidhan Sabha after spending nearly 17 years in Parliament. He also noted that the BJP had made him a Union minister despite his defeat in the 2024 Lok Sabha elections.

Expressing confidence about the party’s prospects, Bittu said people in Punjab were “fed up” with existing political parties and were looking for development similar to that seen in BJP-ruled states.

The grandson of former Punjab chief minister Beant Singh,

who was assassinated in 1995, Bittu joined the BJP ahead of the 2024 Lok Sabha elections after a long stint in the Congress. He represented Anandpur Sahib in 2009 and Ludhiana in 2014 and 2019 as a Congress MP before unsuccessfully contesting the 2024 Lok Sabha election from Ludhiana, where he lost to Congress leader Amrinder Singh Raja Warring.

Following his defeat, Bittu was nominated to the Rajya Sabha from Rajasthan for the remainder of the term of a seat vacated by Congress leader K C Venugopal and joined the Union Council of Ministers in 2024.

Bittu has recently taken an active role in strengthening the BJP’s organisation in Punjab. His criticism of the Diljit Dosanjh-starrer Satluj reflected the party’s outreach strategy aimed at key voter groups, including Sikhs, Hindus, Dalits and Other Backward Classes, ahead of the Assembly election campaign.

US slaps 10%

economies a day before the expiry of a temporary 10 per cent import tax imposed on all countries. According to the USTR, the action was taken under Section 301 of the Trade Act of 1974 against economies that failed to prohibit and effectively enforce restrictions on goods produced using forced labour.

Of the 60 economies covered, 17, including India, Canada, the United Kingdom, Bangladesh and Pakistan, will face a 10 per cent tariff, while the remaining 43 will attract a 12.5 per cent duty. Countries without laws prohibiting imports made with forced labour, including China, Japan and the UK, will be subject to the higher rate. The tariffs will not apply to certain raw materials, products that could disrupt the US economy, or goods that cannot be produced in sufficient quantities domestically.

The new tariffs take effect at 12.01 am Friday as the temporary import tax expires. That measure had been introduced after the US Supreme Court, in February, struck down the Trump administration’s reciprocal tariffs imposed under emergency powers.

India has challenged both USTR investigations and maintains that such issues should be addressed through the bilateral trade agreement currently under negotiation. Bilateral goods trade between the two countries stood at nearly USD 141 billion in 2025, including USD 87.3 billion in Indian exports. According to The Washington Post, the Trump administration is expected to announce another round of tariffs within weeks targeting countries that subsidise excess manufacturing capacity.

Himachal

Bystanders, Army personnel and rescue teams rushed to the spot, around 70 km from the district headquarters in Keylong, and tried to douse the flames. Police said relief and res-

cue operations began immediately after the accident was reported. The Border Roads Organisation, local administration and police are leading the operation. Officials said the site has no telecom connectivity, making rescue efforts more challenging.

Among those killed were seven men, four women and the infant, while one victim was yet to be identified. Police identified the deceased as Bir Singh, Sanjay Kumar, Hans Raj, Budhi Singh, Bir Singh, Anil Kumar, Saurabh Singh, Anjana, Soman Angmo, Rekha, Kamla Kumari and six-month-old Aaru. Most of the victims were residents of Pangi in Chamba district.

Bharmour MLA Janak Raj said that only the two passengers who jumped out of the vehicle survived. He appealed to the deputy commissioners of Chamba and Lahaul-Spiti to speed up rescue and relief work.

Preliminary information suggests the passengers had been stranded at Tindi after the Udaipur-Killar road remained closed a day earlier. They resumed their journey on Friday after the route reopened.

Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu expressed grief over the deaths and directed the deputy commissioner of Lahaul-Spiti to supervise rescue operations. He instructed authorities to provide all possible assistance to the families of those killed and the best treatment to the injured. “He prayed for strength to the bereaved family members to bear the irreparable loss,” the Chief Minister’s Office said.

In a separate incident in Mandi district, a woman died and seven others were injured after a landslide struck a family travelling from Kullu to the Simsa Mata Temple in Jogindernagar’s Gumma area. Landslide incidents have increased across Himachal Pradesh following continuous rainfall in recent days.

SC bars

personally experienced misreporting, recalling that remarks never made by him had been attributed to him in print. Referring to a recent case listing, he said media reports claimed he had refused to hear a matter even though no petition had been filed before 10 am that day.

Observing that regulating digital data had become one of the biggest challenges, the bench said there was a need to preserve the sanctity of judicial institutions. It directed the Supreme Court secretary general and registrar generals of all high courts to publish the interim order on their official websites.

The petition states that while live streaming and video conferencing were introduced to promote transparency and open justice, the absence of a regulatory framework has led to the misuse of recordings. It says courtroom exchanges are often presented through isolated clips with misleading captions and sensational headlines, exposing judges, lawyers and litigants to trolling and reputational harm while risking public confidence in the justice system.

CONGRESS ANNOUNCES NATIONWIDE CANDLELIGHT MARCHES

Wave of NEET protest sweeps across states

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The agitation against the NEET paper leak swept several states in India on Friday, a day after the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) called for nationwide demonstrations, with protesters condemning the Delhi Police crackdown on July 20 and demanding the resignation of Union Education minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

With the protest intensifying across states, the Congress directed its state units to organise a candlelight march and 'satyagraha' in each district on Saturday evening to protest against "irregularities in the NEET and CBSE examinations and the subsequent repressive actions by the Modi government".

In Maharashtra's Mumbai, thousands of protesters gathered in Dadar under the banner of Shiv Sena (UBT), with party leader Aaditya Thackeray stating that he has urged CJP founder



Students and youth activists participate in a Cockroach Janta Party (CJP)-led protest march, in Pune, Friday

Abhijeet Dipke not to return to Maharashtra until the demands are met.

Holding tricolours and placards in their hands, thousands of students and activists gathered at the iconic Shivaji Park ground in the Dadar area as part of a 'Tiranga Morcha' organised by the Uddhav Thackeray-led

Sena (UBT).

In neighbouring Pune, protesters, including students, braved heavy rains as they took out a march demanding the resignation of Pradhan and denouncing the lathi-charge by Delhi Police on demonstrators.

In Nagpur, the mother of a NEET aspirant who alleg-

edly committed suicide in May addressed a protest event and sought the resignation of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Pradhan.

In Kolkata, the protest turned violent as clashes broke out between members of the Left students' organisations and police personnel during a pro-

Highlights

» In Maharashtra's Mumbai, thousands of protesters gathered in Dadar under the banner of Shiv Sena (UBT)

» In Southern region, several educational institutions observed a 'bandh' in Telangana and Andhra Pradesh following a call by the Left-affiliated students

PTI

ping up security at multiple locations.

In Chandigarh and Kaithal, the youths were joined by farmers and activists in the demonstration against Delhi Police's crackdown on protesters and seeking Pradhan's resignation.

In South, several educational institutions observed a 'bandh' in Telangana and Andhra following a call by Left-affiliated students. The BRS also held protests seeking the resignation of Pradhan.

In Kerala, the Youth Congress activists held a protest march in Kollam in support of the CJP and student agitation in Delhi regarding the alleged irregularities in the NEET and various other exams held at the national level.

In Tamil Nadu, protests against NEET continued, with hundreds of students taking part, demanding the scrapping of the national-level screening test and resignation of Pradhan.

First week of Monsoon Session washed out amid Oppn uproar

Pradhan's resignation main demand before debate on NEET paper leak issue



Opposition members protest in the well amid proceedings in the Lok Sabha during the Monsoon session of Parliament, in New Delhi, Friday

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The first week of the Monsoon session of Parliament was washed out as the government and the Opposition continued to be at loggerheads over the demand for Education minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation before a debate on NEET paper leak issue in both Houses.

Hitting out at the Opposition, the government said making "excuses" and attaching "pre-conditions" before a debate will send a wrong message to the country.

In the first week of the session, both Houses could not take up any legislative agenda except for introduction of a Bill each in Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha.

In Lok Sabha, a Bill to replace an ordinance which increased the number of judges of the Supreme Court from 34 to 38 was introduced but could not taken up for consideration and passage despite being listed every day.

The Bill has to be passed into an Act of Parliament before the session concludes on August 13 else the ordinance will lapse.

In Lok Sabha, Question Hour could not be held for

even 15 minutes in five days.

In Rajya Sabha, a Bill was introduced on Friday to make insult to the national song Vande Mataram a criminal offence, despite being listed for introduction on multiple days.

When Lok Sabha met at 12 noon after an earlier adjournment, Parliamentary Affairs minister Kiren Rijiju pointed to the Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi and said the government has repeatedly reached out to Opposition parties to let debate on the paper leak take place.

He said while several Opposition MPs are of the view that the debate should take place, Gandhi should make his party members understand the need for a discussion.

Rijiju said making excuses and attaching pre-conditions before a debate will send a wrong message to the country.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has also assured of a stringent law on paper leaks and holding trial of the accused in fast-track courts, he said, while also noting that activist Sonam Wangchuk has ended his hunger strike.

He said the Union Cabinet will take a decision on the proposed law on Friday.

No reports on nationwide shortage of anti-rabies vaccine: Nadda tells LS

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Union Health minister JP Nadda on Friday told the Lok Sabha that the government has not received any reports indicating a nationwide shortage of anti-rabies vaccine (ARV).

However, temporary local shortages may occur in some health facilities due to increased demand, procurement delays or supply chain issues, and such situations are addressed by the concerned state and Union Territory governments through redistribution of available stocks, emergency procurement and strengthening of supply chain management, he said.

Nadda clarified that health is a state subject and the pri-

'However, temporary local shortages may occur in some health facilities due to increased demand, procurement delays or supply chain issues'

mary responsibility for procurement, distribution and ensuring uninterrupted availability of anti-rabies vaccine (ARV) and rabies immunoglobulin (RIG) in public health facilities rests with the respective state and UT governments.

"The Government of India has not received reports indicating any nationwide shortage of Anti-Rabies Vaccine," he said.

The minister said the Centre continuously reviews the implementation of the National Rabies Control Programme (NRCP) through periodic review meetings with states and union territories.

He said advisories are issued from time to time to all states to maintain uninterrupted supply of ARV and RIG through funds allocated under the National Free Drug Initiative (NFDI).

Under the National Health Mission (NHM), the Centre provides technical and financial support to states for strengthening their healthcare systems based on proposals submitted by them in their Programme Implementation Plans, subject to norms and availability of resources, Nadda said.

'Eyewash, headline-grabbing exercise'

Cong slams PM's 'paper leak fast-track courts' pitch

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Congress on Friday termed as an "eyewash" Prime Minister Narendra Modi's announcement to set up fast-track courts to punish those involved in paper leaks and said it was an attempt to show responsiveness where there is none.

Congress general secretary in-charge communications Jairam Ramesh said his party's demands are clear -- "sack Mantri Pradhan; punish those who beat the students; apologise to the students."

Ramesh said the Modi government is trying its hardest to play up the PM's "midnight panic promise" of fast-track courts by law.

"Actually just this morning

'The Pradhan Mantri is only attempting to fool the youth'

the Delhi High Court has constituted a new Fast-Track Court with immediate effect to hear cases under the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024. Fast-track courts can easily and clearly be set up under existing laws as well. The PM's promise is, as usual, hollow and only a headline-grabbing exercise," Ramesh alleged.

The Pradhan Mantri is only attempting to fool the youth, he alleged. Ramesh said the fast-track courts work only when investigations themselves are thorough and time-bound and

there is political will to see the investigations through.

"The Modi government's 'niyat' (intentions) over the last 12 years has been clear -- to deny that paper leaks have occurred, and to suppress investigations.

"What else explains the following -- the Mantri Pradhan deliberately refused to use the word 'leak' for the NEET-UG 2026 exam in his press conference; the Education Ministry officially denied that a paper leak occurred in the NEET-UG 2026 exam to the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Education; the Modi government deliberately buried and denied the evidence of widespread irregularities in the NEET-UG 2024 despite the extremely fishy clustering of exam toppers in a handful of test centers," he said.

Table statehood restoration Bill this Parl session, Farooq Abdullah urges Centre

SRINAGAR: National Conference president Farooq Abdullah on Friday called for the introduction and passing of a Bill to restore the statehood of Jammu and Kashmir during the ongoing Monsoon Session of Parliament.

Reiterating the party's long standing demand, Abdullah urged the Central government to honour its repeated commitments by introducing and passing the statehood restoration Bill during the ongoing session.

"People of Jammu and Kashmir have waited long enough. The restoration of statehood is not merely a political demand but a constitutional and democratic imperative," he said in a statement.

The three-time chief minister said that Parliament must seize this opportunity to fulfil the govt's solemn assurances given repeatedly to the people of Jammu and Kashmir and restore their democratic rights and dignity without any further delay.

He also commended the Omar Abdullah-led government for its "prompt, compassionate and hands-on" response in tackling the challenges arising out of the recent inclement weather in the Union Territory.

The elected government's swift intervention and continuous monitoring of the situation have provided timely relief to the affected people, Farooq Abdullah said, adding that this reflected its commitment to public welfare.

He appreciated the chief minister for personally overseeing relief and restoration efforts, undertaking field visits, reviewing the situation with the civil administration and ensuring that rescue, rehabilitation and essential services are restored at the earliest.

The NC chief urged all party legislators, party functionaries and workers to remain on the ground, stay in close touch with the people, and extend every possible assistance to those affected.



Maternal grandparents' custody of child not illegal: Calcutta High Court

SOUMYADIP MULLICK

KOLKATA: The Calcutta High Court has refused to hand over the custody of a minor boy to his father, holding that the child's welfare must take precedence and that custody cannot be transferred merely because the father is the natural guardian when he is living abroad.

A Division Bench of Justice Debangsu Basak and Justice Ajay Kumar Gupta was hearing a habeas corpus petition filed by a man employed in Saudi Arabia seeking custody of his son after the death of the child's mother. The court held that the child had been staying with his maternal grandparents since his mother's death and that such custody could not be treated as illegal.

According to the case records, the couple married in

The Case

» According to the case records, the couple married in October 2022 and the husband left for Saudi Arabia in November 2024

» Before her death in May 2025, the wife had approached the HC seeking custody of child

October 2022 and the husband left for Saudi Arabia in November 2024. The wife later lodged two police complaints alleging torture and dowry-related harassment against her husband and his relatives. A civil suit between the parties is also pending.

Before her death in May

2025, the wife had approached the High Court seeking custody of the child. That petition was disposed of in June 2025. She had taken the child to her parental home, where the boy continued to stay with his maternal grandparents after her death.

The father argued that he was entitled to custody through the writ petition. The High Court, however, observed that he was still outside India and was expected to return only in November. In such circumstances, the Bench said it could not conclude that immediately transferring custody to the father would serve the child's best interests. The court further observed that the father was aware of the child's present location and that the custody of the maternal grandparents could not be termed illegal.

India expands medical education

Number of medical colleges more than doubled since 2014, says govt

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The number of medical colleges in India has increased from 387 in 2014 to 844 now, while undergraduate MBBS seats have grown from 51,348 to 1,39,489, Minister of State for Health Anupriya Patel said on Friday.

In a written reply to a question in the Lok Sabha, the minister also said that postgraduate medical seats have increased from 31,185 to 86,360 in the same time period.

The minister said the establishment of new medical colleges in remote and underserved regions, along with the expansion of MBBS seats, is expected to improve the availability of doctors and strengthen healthcare delivery across the country.

Patel also highlighted the Family Adoption Programme (FAP), which has been integrated into the MBBS curriculum.

Under the programme, medical colleges adopt villages, while MBBS students adopt families within those villages to provide regular follow-up on vaccination, growth moni-

Key Points

» Patel also said that postgraduate medical seats have increased from 31,185 to 86,360 in the same time period

» Patel also highlighted the Family Adoption Programme (FAP), which has been integrated into the MBBS curriculum

» Patel said that under the

National Health Mission (NHM), the performance of health programmes is regularly monitored

» The Ministry of Health and Family Welfare has launched several initiatives to improve service delivery, including integrated training modules in collaboration with regional training institutes

NITI Aayog found encouraging outcomes, including improved infrastructure and higher community footfall due to expanded access to comprehensive primary healthcare services.

The study cited better availability of care for non-communicable diseases (NCDs), outpatient services, free medicines and diagnostic facilities.

According to the minister, the deployment of Community Health Officers has strengthened frontline healthcare delivery, while digital platforms such as e-Sanjeevani have expanded access to specialist consultations.

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: Protests in support of the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) spread across Uttar Pradesh on Friday as students, lawyers and Opposition workers staged demonstrations in several districts, demanding action over the alleged police crackdown on student protesters and targeting the Centre over the handling of the agitation.

In Prayagraj, lawyers took out a protest march and accused the authorities of using excessive force against students. Addressing the gathering, members of the legal fraternity said those who were lathi-charged were "our children" and warned that the agitation would now move from campuses to the streets.

In Meerut, Samajwadi Party



People hold placards as they take out a protest march in support of the ongoing demonstration at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi over NEET paper leak issue, in Lucknow, Friday

PTI

workers carried out a symbolic funeral procession of Union Education minister Dharmendra Pradhan. Police intervened and seized the symbolic bier, leading to a brief confrontation. During the protest, one SP worker lay down on the road

in an attempt to stop the police before being removed by security personnel.

In Kanpur, a Samajwadi Party MLA staged a protest by beating a traditional hand drum, while in Lakhimpur Kheri, students carrying

the national flag and placards marched to the district collectorate. They handed roses to the Sub-Divisional Magistrate as a symbolic mark of protest and submitted a memorandum.

The demonstrations followed CJP's nationwide call for protests, prompting police across Uttar Pradesh to remain on high alert to prevent any law and order situation.

In Muzaffarnagar, Bharatiya Kisan Union national spokesperson Rakesh Tikait accused the government of attempting to portray the students' agitation as violent. He said the movement was not extremist but a struggle by young people demanding employment opportunities. He also alleged that the police action reflected the govt's approach towards the protesters.

PM hails Cabinet decisions on Railway lines, chemical parks

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday hailed the Union Cabinet's approval of 3rd and 4th railway lines on the Ballari-Guntakal section and a new Rs 3,030-crore scheme to set up three large chemical parks.

He said the moves will strengthen connectivity and will reduce logistics and production costs, attract investment and enhance exports. A corpus of Rs 1,264 crore has been approved to add a third and fourth rail line on the Ballari-Guntakal section spanning Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh. The railway lines will improve access to important cultural and tourist destinations, reduce congestion and generate new economic opportunities, the prime minister said on X.

On the approval for Bharat Audyogik Vikas Yojana Rasayan, or BHAVYA-Rasayan Scheme, to establish three dedicated chemical parks in the country, Modi said it marks an important step towards strengthening India's chemical and petrochemical ecosystem.

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Nation Briefs

IRS OFFICER SATYA PAL KUMAR APPOINTED FIU DIRECTOR; 20 JS POSTED

NEW DELHI: Indian Revenue Services (IRS) officer Satya Pal Kumar has been appointed as director of the Financial Intelligence Unit as part of a major joint secretary-level reshuffle affected by the Union government on Friday. Kumar is a 2005-batch IRS officer of the Income Tax Department cadre. The FIU is a national agency under the Union finance ministry responsible for receiving, processing, analysing and disseminating information relating to suspect financial transactions in Indian economic channels to various enforcement agencies. Among the other key appointments made by the Appointments Committee of the Cabinet (ACC), Avانش Kumar Mishra, ISS (2000), was named joint secretary in the Department of Administrative Reforms and Public Grievances.

OPPOSITION PROTESTS MARK BIHAR MONSOON SESSION; HOUSE ADJOURNED SINE DIE

Patna: The five-day monsoon session of the Bihar legislature was adjourned sine die on Friday, with the proceedings witnessing repeated protests and disruptions by Opposition members over various issues, including NEET paper leak and student protests across the state. Assembly Speaker Prem Kumar adjourned the House sine die, bringing the brief session to a close. During the session, both Houses of the state legislature passed the Bihar Appropriation (No. 3) Bill, 2026, paving the way for the state government to withdraw more than Rs 87,383 crore from the treasury for the 2026-27 financial year.



SECOND SHIP TARGETED

Indian killed in Black Sea attack; New Delhi rejects Russia's claim

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: India on Friday strongly condemned attacks on commercial shipping after an Indian national was killed in a strike on a merchant vessel in the Black Sea, even as New Delhi rejected Russia's claim that another ship, on which four Indians were killed earlier this week, was carrying military cargo.

The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said the commercial vessel MV OMORFI was attacked on July 18 while reportedly transiting Russian territorial waters in the Black Sea. The vessel had 10 crew members, including three Indian nationals.

According to the MEA, one Indian sailor was killed in the attack, while the other two Indians on board are safe. The Indian Embassy in Russia has contacted the relevant authorities and is extending all possible assistance to the deceased sailor's family.

"India unequivocally condemns such attacks targeting commercial shipping and placing the lives of innocent civilian crew members at risk," the ministry said, adding that threats to freedom of navigation and international commerce are a matter of serious concern. It urged all parties to uphold international obligations to ensure the safety of maritime navigation and the uninterrupted flow of global trade.

The latest incident was reported just days after four Indian seafarers were among 10 people killed in a Russian strike on the Guinea-Bissau-flagged merchant vessel MV Golden Leo off Ukraine's Odesa port on July 19.



Smoke rises from the grain carrier Golden Leo under the Guinea-Bissau flag after Russian missile strike in the Black Sea close to Odesa, Ukraine, on July 19

AP/PTI

HIGHLIGHTS

- » India on Friday strongly condemned attacks on commercial shipping after an Indian national was killed in a strike on a merchant vessel in the Black Sea
- » New Delhi also rejected Russia's claim that another ship, on which

- four Indians were killed earlier this week, was carrying military cargo
- » Citing information from the Directorate General of Maritime Administration, the MEA said the vessel had loaded grain before departing Odesa on July 19

Responding to Moscow's assertion that Russia would continue attacking ships allegedly carrying arms for Ukraine, External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said the MV Golden Leo was transporting grain, not military hardware. Citing information from the Directorate General of Maritime Administration, he said the vessel had loaded grain before departing Odesa on July 19, effectively rejecting Russia's justification for the attack.

"We once again reiterate that commercial shipping and seafarers must not be targeted under any circumstances," Jaiswal said at a regular media briefing. He added that Exter-

nal Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar conveyed India's position to Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov during their meeting in Manila on Wednesday.

Earlier this week, India summoned Russian Charge d'Affaires Vladimir Ladanov to convey its "grave concerns" and "unequivocal condemnation" over the attack on the MV Golden Leo. The incident marked the first deaths of Indian seafarers linked to the Russia-Ukraine conflict.

New Delhi has reiterated its demand that all sides respect international maritime law and ensure the safety of civilian vessels and seafarers operating in conflict zones.

Manipur violence cases: SC proposes special courts, seeks 'speedy completion' of probes

Manipur government told to provide full cooperation to probe agencies

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Friday proposed setting up special courts to conduct day-to-day trials in criminal cases arising from the 2023 ethnic violence in Manipur. It also directed probe agencies to expeditiously complete pending investigations and ensure that victims receive copies of chargesheets.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana took note of the fact that many victims and their families are yet to get copies of the chargesheets filed by the CBI and the state SIT in criminal cases. The lawyers will have to be provided the chargesheets within one week of legal aid counsel contacting them, the court said.

More than 200 people have



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

been killed, several hundred injured and thousands displaced since ethnic violence first broke out in Manipur on May 3, 2023.

Hearing a batch of pleas relating to the violence, the apex court permitted the legal aid counsel representing the victims to approach the offices of the Gauhati and Manipur chief justices to seek copies of the chargesheets.

Senior advocate Vrinda Grover informed the bench

that despite previous directions, the families of two deceased victims had told her they had still not received the copies. She said one legal aid counsel had received the documents while another was still awaiting them.

The law officer clarified that chargesheets were sensitive criminal records and required to be furnished only to victims and their lawyers and not to women's groups or public interest litigants.

"We are informed by (Vrinda) Grover that regardless of the directions or status report, she has been informed by victim families that chargesheets have not been supplied to them. She was able to contact the legal aid counsels, one of whom has received a chargesheet. Others are awaited," the bench said.

"We direct the legal aid

counsels to immediately contact the office of the chief justices of high courts Manipur and Gauhati. The authorities will ensure supply of chargesheets not later than one week from the date legal aid counsel contacts them," it ordered.

The apex court said it was tentatively proposing special courts with concurrence of the state of Manipur, the high courts of Manipur and Gauhati for day-to-day trials due to the inordinate delay in investigation.

The bench also directed the Manipur government to provide full cooperation and assist agencies.

It asked the CBI, state SIT and the court-appointed monitoring committee headed by former Maharashtra DGP Datatray Padsalgikar to file fresh status reports about the violence-related cases.

UP Chief Secy orders rollout of 'e-Zero FIR'

LUCKNOW: Uttar Pradesh Chief Secretary S P Goyal on Friday directed officials to operationalise the e-Zero FIR system and appoint cyber awareness nodal officers in every government department, saying the state should strive to become the country's leader in cyber security.

According to an official statement, chairing a high-level review meeting, Goyal reviewed Uttar Pradesh's progress on nine cyber crime-related priority areas under the Prime Minister's PRAGATI review mechanism.

"All departments concerned should work in coordination to ensure action against cyber crimes. Swift action must be taken against cyber criminals and such cases should be monitored regularly," he said.

Goyal approved a proposal of the Cyber Crime Headquarters to appoint a nodal officer in every government department.

MPOST

POLICE CLUSTER MEET

Women's judo: CISF finishes runners-up

HYDERABAD: The Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) finished runners-up in the women's judo event in the 11th All India Police Judo Cluster Championship 2026 in Hyderabad. Organised under the aegis of the All India Police Sports Control Board (AIPSCB), the championship began on Thursday at the CISF premises and will conclude on July 30.

Around 1,600 athletes and officials from 36 Central Armed Police Forces and state police organisations are participating in the sports meet, being held across five disciplines — Judo, Taekwondo, Wushu,



Karate and Pencak Silat.

The CISF women's team delivered a consistent performance, winning medals in all seven weight categories with two silver and five bronze medals to secure second place. Sashastra Seema Bal (SSB) emerged champions in the women's judo event. Eighteen teams competed, with nine teams finishing in the medal tally.

MPOST

'AD HOCISM HAS CAUSED TROUBLE FOR YEARS'

Apex Court to 'closely monitor' NEET reforms

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Friday told the Centre that it will closely monitor the steps taken to curb NEET examination paper leaks, while underlining that ad hocism has caused trouble for years.

A bench of Justices P S Narasimha and Alok Aradhe, which was hearing a batch of petitions, including one by the Federation of All India Medical Association (FAIMA), told Solicitor General Tushar Mehta that the government should indicate the steps taken towards transparency, implementation of recommendations of the Radhakrishnan Committee and how the IIT model would be followed.

The seven-member Radhakrishnan Committee was set up by the Ministry of Education in the wake of the NEET-UG



FILE PIC

paper leak to make recommendations on reforms in the examination process, improvement in data security protocols and the structure and functioning of the National Testing Agency (NTA).

One of the pleas sought a direction to replace or restructure the NTA, which is responsible for conducting NEET-UG, with a robust and autonomous body to conduct the medical entrance examination.

Mehta said there are some developments and the government will file a detailed report

on a comprehensive overhaul of the examination process, which may be beyond the recommendations of the Radhakrishnan Committee.

He added that two years back, a similar issue arose and right from printing to transportation, everything was explained to the court.

The bench said the government deployed the Indian Air Force to transport question papers for the NEET-UG retest, but all these measures are ad hoc. "Ad hocism has troubled us for years," Justice Narasimha said, while pointing out that the court will ensure that "institutionalisation of the examination process takes place to avoid a repeat of paper leaks".

While asking the Centre and the NTA to file detailed affidavits, the bench said that

the government has earlier informed the court that IITs will have a role, but it has not been explained.

Advocate Tanvi Dubey, appearing for FAIMA, sought a detailed blueprint of the SOP concerning the computer-based test (CBT) model that will be implemented by the NTA for the NEET-UG examination from next year.

She pointed out that since 22 lakh students will be writing the exam in the CBT mode, it is important that a blueprint of the SOP is provided before the conduct of the examination.

Posting the matter to August 3, the court said it will monitor everything closely and follow it up throughout the year. "We will see that complete and total institutionalisation takes place," the bench said.

MPOST

CBI secures deportation of 2 fugitives

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), in coordination with the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA), the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) and other agencies, has secured the deportation of two fugitives wanted through Interpol Red Notices from the United Arab Emirates (UAE) and Saudi Arabia in separate cases.

In the first case, Avinash Arjun Rathod was deported from the UAE to India on July 23 in connection with an alleged large-scale financial fraud. According to the CBI, Rathod and his associates allegedly duped investors of crores of rupees through fraudulent investment schemes and diverted the funds to various bank and demat accounts. Following the issuance of an Interpol Red Notice, he was traced, deported and handed over to the Maharashtra Police upon his arrival in Mumbai.

In the second case, Muhammedali Kanneer Palliyalil was deported from Saudi Arabia on the same day in coordination with the National Investigation Agency (NIA). He was wanted in connection with a case involving alleged unlawful activities and murder.

The NIA alleged that Palliyalil and his co-conspirators had conspired to enter the victim's shop in broad daylight, assault him with weapons, abduct him to an undisclosed location and kill him. An Interpol Red Notice had also been issued against him. After his arrest, Saudi authorities handed him over to the Indian Embassy and completed the required legal formalities before deporting him to India.

The CBI said both deportations were facilitated with the assistance of the MEA, MHA, Indian missions abroad, foreign governments and law enforcement agencies. It said the action reflects the government's continued efforts to trace, apprehend and bring fugitives accused of crimes in India back to face the legal process.

Delhi meeting: BRICS adopts joint disaster risk reduction statement

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: BRICS nations on Friday adopted a Joint Statement on Disaster Risk Reduction (DRR) at the 3rd BRICS Ministerial Meeting in New Delhi, reaffirming their commitment to strengthening cooperation for building disaster-resilient societies.

Organised by the National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA) under the Ministry of Home Affairs as part of India's BRICS Chairship 2026, the meeting was chaired by Minister of State for Home Affairs Nityanand Rai. Delegates from BRICS member states also reiterated their resolve to operationalise the BRICS Disaster Risk Reduction Work Plan (2025-2028).

Addressing the meeting,



Rai said BRICS cooperation on disaster risk reduction has steadily evolved since the adoption of the Udaipur Declaration on Disaster Risk Reduction in 2016. He noted that the process gained further momentum with the Kazan Declaration on Climate Resilient and Disaster Risk Reduction Infrastructures in 2024 and the establishment of the BRICS Disaster Risk Reduction Group.

He said India, as BRICS Chair in 2026, remains committed to a pragmatic and

results-oriented approach under the theme, "Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability".

The minister highlighted India's people-centric disaster management framework, guided by Prime Minister Narendra Modi's Ten Point Agenda for Disaster Risk Reduction, and stressed the need for greater regional cooperation in early warning systems, climate-resilient infrastructure, science and technology, nature-based solutions and community resilience.

He also informed delegates that BRICS countries would undertake technical exchanges, joint initiatives, simulation exercises and annual thematic work plans to enhance cooperation and promote sustainable, climate-resilient development.

VHP, RSS VIE FOR TRUST'S MOST POWERFUL POST

Ram Temple's CEO may only be the 'face' as 'real power' lies with general secretary

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

TAKEAWAYS

- » Under the Trust's rules, the CEO will function as the executive face of the temple's day-to-day administration
- » The real authority over policy, finance and governance will continue to rest with the General Secretary
- » The Trust has already



FILE PIC

begun the process of selecting a CEO and, according to sources, more than 5,500 applications have been received from across the country

one of the country's most high-profile temple management positions. Despite the attention surrounding the CEO's appointment, the officer will have limited decision-making powers. According to the Trust's constitution, the CEO will report directly to the General Secretary and will be responsible for implementing decisions rather than framing policy.

The CEO's role will primarily cover the temple's daily operations, including darshan management, security, sanitation,

VIP movement, crowd control during festivals, supervision of staff and coordination with the district administration and police. The officer will also maintain financial records and ensure expenditure remains within the budget approved by the Trust. However, every major administrative and financial decision will remain subject to the General Secretary's approval. The General Secretary will appoint the CEO, review the officer's performance and approve the annual budget.

The CEO will also be required to regularly submit reports to the General Secretary, who will continue to exercise overall administrative control.

The Trust's rules vest the General Secretary with sweeping powers. The office controls the Trust's properties, bank accounts and legal documents, approves major construction projects and investments, oversees religious events and policy decisions, and represents the Trust before courts, the Centre, the Uttar Pradesh government and other institutions.

This concentration of authority has made the appointment of the next General Secretary far more significant than the selection of the CEO.

The issue has acquired added importance after the resignation of Champat Rai following the alleged donation theft controversy. Although the Trust's meeting on July 22 was expected to finalise his successor, no consensus could be reached. Krishna Mohan continues as the interim General

Secretary.

Sources said the delay stems from differences over whether the post should go to a nominee of the VHP, which spearheaded the Ram Temple movement, or the RSS, which wants a greater role in the temple's future administration. Another point of discussion is whether the final decision should be taken by the leadership in Delhi or after consultations with influential stakeholders in Uttar Pradesh. Krishna Mohan, who is associated with the RSS, is among the leading contenders. VHP leader Bajrang Lal Bagda is also in the race. Sources, however, said the possibility of a consensus candidate has not been ruled out.

For now, while thousands are competing to become the Ram Temple's first CEO, the more consequential contest remains behind the scenes. Whoever is eventually chosen as General Secretary will hold the keys to the Trust's finances, administration and strategic decision-making.

Nation Briefs

SAD DISTRICT YOUTH CHIEF JOINS AAP

CHANDIGARH: Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) Mansa district youth president Hanish Bansal joined the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) along with his supporters on Friday, giving the ruling party a boost in the district. Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann's OSD Rajbir Ghuman inducted Bansal into the party by presenting him with the AAP's shiropa and welcomed him. Ghuman said the AAP's inclusive policies had attracted people from all sections of society and that Bansal's entry would strengthen the party in Mansa. Bansal said he joined the AAP after being impressed by Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann's pro-people policies and transparent governance.

HARYANA: RETD IAS OFFICER SAMEER PAL SROW APPOINTED QAA CHAIRPERSON

CHANDIGARH: The Haryana government on Friday appointed retired IAS officer Sameer Pal Srow as the chairperson of the Quality Assurance Authority (QAA). Srow brings extensive administrative experience to the role. His appointment is expected to further strengthen the authority's efforts to enhance quality oversight across government programmes and public service delivery. The QAA is responsible for monitoring and evaluating quality standards in government departments, public sector undertakings, and welfare schemes. It also works to promote greater transparency, accountability, and continuous improvement in the implementation of public policies and services.



EDITORIAL

BEYOND THE LENS

The Supreme Court’s decision to prohibit the unauthorised recording and sharing of court proceedings raises an important constitutional question that extends beyond the courtroom itself: how should the judiciary balance transparency with the need to preserve the integrity of justice? At a time when smartphones have turned every public event into potential online content and social media rewards speed over accuracy, the court has chosen to draw a firm boundary around its proceedings. The ruling is neither a rejection of openness nor an attempt to shield judicial functioning from public scrutiny. Rather, it reflects an acknowledgement that courts are not theatres of public spectacle but institutions entrusted with resolving disputes through reasoned deliberation. In an era where edited clips, viral misinformation and online outrage can shape public perception within minutes, the judiciary has recognised that uncontrolled recording poses risks not only to judges and lawyers but also to the fairness of the justice delivery process itself.

The Indian judiciary has, over the past decade, steadily embraced greater openness. Live-streaming of Constitution Bench hearings, publication of judgments online, digital access to case records and virtual court proceedings during the pandemic have collectively expanded public access to justice. These reforms were guided by the principle that justice must not merely be done but must also be seen to be done. Yet transparency has never meant the complete absence of regulation. Even countries with long traditions of open courts maintain strict rules governing photography, filming and broadcasting inside courtrooms. In many jurisdictions, permission is mandatory, recordings are centrally controlled and commercial or unauthorised dissemination is prohibited. The reason is straightforward. Court proceedings involve sensitive testimony, legal strategy, confidential material and, frequently, vulnerable individuals. A courtroom is fundamentally different from a political rally or a public meeting because the objective is to establish facts and interpret the law rather than entertain or persuade an audience.

The dangers of unrestricted recording have become increasingly evident in the digital age. Short video clips extracted from lengthy hearings often strip judicial observations of their legal context. Preliminary remarks made by judges during oral arguments are routinely projected as final conclusions, creating confusion about cases that remain under consideration. Lawyers’ submissions may be selectively edited to suit political narratives or ideological campaigns. Witnesses, litigants and even judges can become targets of online abuse based on incomplete or misleading excerpts. Such distortions undermine confidence in the judicial process rather than strengthening it. Courts decide cases through written judgments after hearing all parties, not through isolated exchanges during hearings. When fragments of proceedings circulate without context, public debate shifts from informed legal analysis to emotionally charged speculation. The resulting “trial by social media” can exert indirect pressure on participants and erode the calm atmosphere necessary for fair adjudication.

The issue also involves the rights and safety of individuals who come before the courts. Not every litigant voluntarily enters a courtroom. Victims of sexual offences, children, whistle-blowers, family members involved in matrimonial disputes and individuals facing threats often seek legal protection under emotionally and socially difficult circumstances. Even where identities are legally protected, unauthorised recordings may inadvertently reveal personal details or expose individuals to harassment. Lawyers too have legitimate concerns about edited clips damaging professional reputations or misrepresenting courtroom exchanges. Judges, meanwhile, must remain insulated from campaigns designed to influence pending matters. Judicial independence depends not only on constitutional safeguards but also on an environment where decisions are made on law and evidence rather than on viral trends or digital pressure.

That said, concerns about restricting recordings cannot simply be dismissed. Open justice remains a foundational democratic principle. Courts exercise enormous public authority, interpret constitutional rights and hold governments accountable. Public confidence in the judiciary depends significantly on transparency. Restrictions that appear overly broad could create apprehensions that judicial proceedings are becoming less accessible to citizens. Such concerns deserve careful attention because secrecy has never been compatible with democratic adjudication. The answer, however, lies not in allowing unrestricted recording by every individual but in strengthening structured, reliable and institutional mechanisms of public access.

This is where technology can become part of the solution rather than the problem. If court proceedings are to be available to the public, the recordings should ideally be produced, archived and disseminated through official channels. Authorised live-streams, complete video archives, accurate transcripts and timely publication of orders can ensure transparency while preventing manipulation. Official recordings preserve context, reduce misinformation and provide an authentic record of proceedings for researchers, journalists and the general public. Several courts across the world already follow such models, balancing openness with institutional control. India’s own experience with live-streaming Constitution Bench hearings demonstrates that carefully regulated digital access can enhance public understanding without compromising judicial decorum.

The media also carries significant responsibility. Court reporting has traditionally relied on accuracy, context and professional ethics rather than sensationalism. The rise of digital platforms has altered this landscape, with headlines and short video snippets often prioritising engagement over nuance. Journalists covering judicial proceedings must resist the temptation to reduce complex legal arguments into misleading soundbites. Equally, legal commentators and social media influencers should recognise that oral observations during hearings are not judicial verdicts. Responsible reporting strengthens public faith in the courts, while selective amplification of exchanges risks reducing constitutional adjudication to performative content.

Ultimately, the Supreme Court’s decision should be viewed not as an attempt to restrict transparency but as an effort to preserve the integrity of judicial proceedings in a transformed information ecosystem. Technology has undeniably expanded access to institutions, but it has also magnified the consequences of misinformation, selective editing and digital harassment. The challenge before the judiciary is to ensure that openness does not become vulnerability. Courts must remain accessible, accountable and understandable, but they must also remain places where disputes are resolved through evidence, legal reasoning and constitutional principles rather than through the pressures of algorithm-driven public opinion.

The future of judicial transparency therefore lies in calibrated openness. Citizens should have greater access to authentic information about court proceedings, but that access must come through systems that protect context, privacy and the fairness of trials. The Supreme Court’s ruling recognises that justice cannot flourish if every courtroom exchange becomes fodder for viral content divorced from its legal setting. In protecting the dignity of judicial proceedings, the court is also protecting the conditions necessary for impartial justice. The task ahead is to ensure that regulation is accompanied by greater institutional transparency, proving that the pursuit of open justice and the preservation of judicial integrity are not competing goals but complementary democratic obligations.

AT VANTAGE



SHUTAPA PAUL

THE WRITER IS AN AUTHOR AND MEDIA ENTREPRENEUR

The answer to these protests is not tear gas or police atrocities; it’s not turning a deaf ear or pretending that these thousands of students don’t exist

I come from the state of protests. In Bengal, voicing dissent is as common as the matir bharer cha (tea in earthen cups) found in street corners and the mellifluous Rabindrasangeet streaming in almost every home. In the state, even a sitting chief minister could be participating in a dharna. Student politics dictate the atmosphere of colleges and universities; and where, long after the Naxalite uprising and quelling of the 70s, students still continue to participate in various kinds of protests. When I was studying in St. Xavier’s, a college not particularly known for student activism, our counterparts in other colleges would enjoy lecture cancellations every other day due to some student agitation or the other. Student unions would clash with each other over divergent ideologies or a crude bomb would go off in a skirmish. Students from colleges such as Bangabasi, Asutosh, Charu Chandra, City College, Surendranath, etc. were famous and notorious for their student politics. Each college in Kolkata approached dissent differently but the students’ voice was largely accepted and acknowledged.

Like in many places in the world, India too has a rich history of student protests, that have in many instances, been the harbinger of change. Our students have protested the Partition of Bengal in 1905, played a proactive role in the Indian freedom struggle through enthused participation in the Non-cooperation (1920) and Quit India (1942) Movements. Post-Independence, the student campaigns shifted to picketing against linguistic hegemony as seen in the anti-Hindi protests (1965) in Tamil Nadu and support to armed agrarian revolt (better known as the Naxalbari movement of 1967) in West Bengal. There were several other large and small student protests that are etched in Indian history including the Navnirman Andolan (1974) in Gujarat against high hostel bills and government corruption, and the pivotal Bihar



The solution is to listen; it is to admit that these students have lost faith in the system; it is to promise to rebuild that institutional trust for them

Movement and JP Movement (1974-75) against unemployment and government corruption, that contributed to Jayaprakash Narayan’s *Sampoorna Kranti* (Total Revolution) that eventually led to the declaration of Emergency (1975) in the country.

Students are inherently anti-establishment; they rage against the administration, they are unfettered by social and economic taboos, they have no masters to please. Unbothered, unchained, and free to exercise their will at that young age — the youth of India has spearheaded many protests in the past. And when they do, as they are now at Jantar Mantar and several spots across the nation, it pays to quickly understand, accept, and address their concerns. Today’s protesters are a generation that has learnt the internet before anything else. They have literally been brought up, shaped, and nurtured by social media. Now they are using those very skills along with a generous dose of humour, antics, and dra-

matics to get their point across. And while we may agree or disagree with their methods, we can’t deny their message. The students of India are demanding a change; a revamp of an education system that is beleaguered with corruption and inefficiency. Repetitive examination leaks have cost students time, money, and precious effort. When they have lost hope, several have chosen death. It’s a system whose expiration date has long passed. And when pleas, tears, and requests fell to an unyielding administration; the students did what they have always done — protested.

The answer to these protests is not tear gas or police atrocities; it’s not turning a deaf ear or pretending that these thousands of students don’t exist; it’s not to deny them the right to protest as guaranteed by our Constitution to every Indian citizen. The solution is to listen; it is to admit that these students have lost faith in the system; it is to promise to rebuild that institutional trust for them. The students

want to be heard — and therefore, it’s important to engage with them and start a dialogue proving that they are not just a valued consumer group for companies but rather an intrinsic stakeholder of Indian democracy. It’s crucial for all of us to understand the angst and fear that’s fuelling the movement of a generation that continues to face life-changing global and natural disasters. From studying virtually during Covid-19 pandemic to having futures thwarted as international borders increasingly become narrower for Indian students to job losses triggered by Artificial Intelligence (AI) and weaker economies caused by ongoing wars — Gen Z stares at disrupted education, delayed careers, uncertain futures, and certain anxieties. We cannot solve everything but it’s our collective responsibility to pave the path for future generations and leave them with a world that’s at least slightly better than the one we inherited.

Views expressed are personal

Flowing Towards Consensus

Decades-old interstate river disputes over the Kishau, Yamuna and Sardar Sarovar projects show negotiated consensus can achieve what prolonged litigation could not

India has always been a civilisation built around its rivers. Those rivers have nurtured kingdoms and continue to witness the nation’s journey through history. They are the lifelines of the people and undoubtedly the country’s spiritual consciousness.

‘Ganga krita papani, Narmada drishta harati,’ is a saying in Sanskrit, which means that, while sins are cleansed by taking a holy dip in the Ganges, they are washed away simply by looking at the Narmada. This is the reverence historically paid to the rivers of our nation.

Unfortunately, over a long period of time, India experienced a paradox. The very rivers that carry the nation together became subject to prolonged disputes between states. From water-sharing to cost-sharing conflicts, several projects have been subsequently delayed for years.

For a nation where rivers have always symbolised unity, the developments of the last few weeks indeed carry great significance. Long-pending interstate water disputes have finally found a way forward. The Kishau Multipurpose Project, the Yamuna Water Project, and the financial settlement relating to the Sardar Sarovar Project have all reached consensus through dialogue.

Under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the central government has consistently articulated the vision of ‘Saath, Sabka Vikas, Sabka Vishwas, Sabka Prayas.’ The recent resolutions stand as a testament to ‘Sabka Prayas’ which emphasise the belief that enduring challenges can only be overcome through collective effort. This has now been executed.

Under the chairmanship of Union Home and Cooperation Minister Amit Shah, states chose consensus over conflict. It is this spirit of cooperative federalism that has finally transformed years of deadlock through decisive action.

The Kishau Multipurpose Project stands as one of the strongest illustrations of this approach. Valued at nearly ₹15,000 crore, the project was stalled for almost eight years due to disagreements over



Rivers continue to flow from one state to another and nourish people without any drop of discrimination

cost-sharing. Under Shah’s chairmanship, a landmark consensus was reached among Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Delhi, Uttar Pradesh, Haryana, and Rajasthan, which now paves the way for the project’s implementation.

Recognising its national significance, the central government committed to bearing 90% of the water component cost as ‘Central Assistance,’ with the remaining 10% to be shared by the participating states. More importantly, a remarkable consensus was forged whereby Himachal Pradesh’s share of water would be allocated to Delhi and Rajasthan, while those states would proportionately bear the financial responsibility for Himachal Pradesh’s share of the power component.

The hurdle was never engineering but consensus building. The six states were convened by Shah, and after discussions, an understanding was reached that benefited everyone. Thus, the outcome: a win-win situation for all stakeholders. The agreement promises long-term regional development, including improved drinking water availability and cleaner flows in the Yamuna

basin. Hence, when ‘Sabka Prayas’ is emphasised, it eventually results in ‘Sabka Vikas.’

The same approach became visible in the agreement between Haryana and Rajasthan on the Yamuna Water Project. For nearly three decades, the issue remained unresolved despite discussions. Now the situation is such that both the states signed a landmark agreement that will enable nearly 580 million cubic metres of water supply to Rajasthan through the Western Yamuna Canal system. Three underground pipelines will also increase water availability in regions of Rajasthan and Haryana.

Decades-pending financial obligations arising under the Narmada Award remained unresolved among Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, and Rajasthan. Finally, under Amit Shah’s leadership, these have now been resolved through a historic one-time settlement among the respective states. This now allows participating states to focus on development rather than inherited disputes.

Symbolically, it carries even greater significance. The Narmada has long been celebrated in Indian

tradition as a river of continuity and spiritual renewal. Resolving decades-old disagreements regarding projects associated with it reinforces the message that finding solutions through dialogue is always possible if one holds the will for it. Ultimately, it is the nation and its citizens that benefit from them.

Collectively, these agreements reflect a model where the leadership does not act as a mere commanding authority but as a facilitator of dialogue. Shah’s efforts have demonstrated that the strongest vertical of cooperative federalism is coordination.

Rivers have never recognised man-made boundaries. They continue to flow from one state to another and nourish people without any drop of discrimination. Governance too must rise above disagreements. The journey towards ‘Viksit Bharat 2047’ is of India as a whole, which most prominently requires the coordination of all its states, with any kind of regional or political differences kept aside.

Prosperity of the states ultimately leads to that of the nation.

Views expressed are personal

‘India imports 25 lakh tonnes of urea, 7 lakh tonnes of DAP in Q1’

Total fertiliser production stood at 115.72 lakh tonnes during the Q1 of FY27, Chemicals & Fertilizers Minister J P Nadda informed Lok Sabha

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India has imported 25.08 lakh tonnes of urea and 7.11 lakh tonnes of di-ammonium phosphate (DAP) during April-June this fiscal to meet domestic demand, according to the government data.

In a written reply to Lok Sabha, Chemicals and Fertilizers Minister J P Nadda informed that the total fertiliser production stood at 115.72 lakh tonnes during the first quarter of this fiscal.

Out of the total production in the June quarter, the urea production stood at 71.55 lakh tonnes while the DAP (di-ammonium phosphate) output was at 9.84 lakh tonnes.

During the 2025-26 fiscal, the total fertiliser production stood at 517.74 lakh tonnes.

As per the data, urea imports stood at 25.08 lakh tonnes while the DAP imports at 7.11 lakh tonnes during April-June this fiscal.

In the entire 2025-26 fiscal, the urea imports stood at 103.50 lakh tonnes. The DAP imports were 61.94 lakh



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tonnes.

“The government has undertaken sustained efforts to diversify import sources to mitigate risks arising from global supply chain disruptions,” Nadda said.

To strengthen fertiliser supply security, he said the government has facilitated long-term commercial arrangements between Indian fertiliser companies and overseas suppliers.

HIGHLIGHTS

- » During the 2025-26 fiscal, the total fertiliser production stood at 517.74 lakh tonnes
- » As per the data, urea imports stood at 25.08 lakh tonnes while the DAP imports at 7.11 lakh tonnes during April-June this fiscal
- » In the entire 2025-26 fiscal, the urea imports stood at 103.50 lakh tonnes. The DAP imports were 61.94 lakh tonnes
- » Indian fertiliser cos have entered into pacts with Russian suppliers for the import of about 26.50 lakh tonnes of DAP/NPK fertilisers this year

Nadda said the Department of Fertilizers has engaged with Indian Missions abroad to identify and explore alternative sources of supply from various countries, thereby reducing dependence on any single

country including China.

“While China has reportedly withheld exports of specialty fertilisers to India, Indian companies have been actively diversifying and sourcing water soluble fertilisers from alternative suppliers in Belgium, Egypt, Germany, Morocco and USA to offset the shortfall caused by reduced imports from China,” the minister said.

To mitigate the global disruptions and ensure uninterrupted supply of fertilisers, Nadda said the Long Term Agreements (LTA) have been finalised between Indian fertiliser companies and Saudi Arabian companies for the annual supply of about 31 lakh tonnes of DAP to India.

Similarly, Indian fertiliser companies have entered into agreements with Russian suppliers for the import of about 26.50 lakh tonnes of DAP/NPK fertilisers this year.

Moreover, for the supply of MOP (muriate of potash), Indian companies have finalised agreements for 4.80 lakh tonnes this year from Russia, Germany and Turkmenistan.

Govt brings ₹3,030 cr scheme for setting up 3 large chemical parks

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The government on Friday announced a new Rs 3,030-crore scheme for setting up three large chemical parks, each spreading across at least 2,000 acres, an initiative aimed at making India self-reliant in the sector.

Announcing the Cabinet decision, Information & Broadcasting Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said each park could see investments in the range of Rs 20,000 crore to Rs 50,000 crore and the scheme will act as a “multiplier”.

The Cabinet, chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, has approved Bharat Audyogik Vikas Yojana Rasayan, or BHAVYA-Rasayan Scheme, to establish three dedicated chemical parks in the country.

The scheme, announced in the Union Budget of the 2026-27 fiscal, will have a total financial outlay of Rs 3,030 crore.

According to an official statement, Rs 3,000 crore would be towards the cost of establishing the common infrastructure facilities and basic utilities inside the parks. The remaining Rs 30 crore will be for the administrative expenditure. The scheme would run for a period of 5 years from the current fiscal to 2030-31.

Replying to a question, Vaishnaw said that the total investment for establishment of these three parks will be significantly higher than this. The

The scheme would run for a period of 5 years from the current fiscal to fiscal 2030-31

outlay (Rs 3,030 crore) is only for common infrastructure.”

The investments on each park could be to the tune of Rs 20,000 crore to Rs 50,000 crore, he said, adding that the scheme would act as a “multiplier” in attracting investments.

“The Centre will facilitate development of three dedicated chemical parks by the state governments under challenge route. Each such park will have a minimum contiguous area of 8 sq km (minimum 2,000 acres) of encumbrance-free land,” the statement said.

The chemical parks could be greenfield or brownfield, depending on the state governments’ selection based on the challenge route, Vaishnaw said.

The minister said that there are many sectors in the economy that are “foundational”, and the chemical sector is one of them, as it provides basic raw materials for many other industries.

The Centre would provide a grant of up to Rs 1,000 crore per park. However, this will be subject to the minimum contribution of Rs 500 crore by the concerned state government, the statement said.

About the benefits, the government said the introduction of the scheme would facilitate “development of the sector by attracting domestic and foreign investments, enhancing domestic production capacity and generating employment.”

It will boost the global competitiveness of the sector, thereby promoting Atmanirbharta, the statement said.

The scheme will promote development of the chemical industry along the whole value chains, including upstream, downstream and ancillary industries. Giving details, the government said the proposed three parks will provide plug-and-play infrastructure in the form of common facilities and basic utilities for the chemical industry.

The facilities include a common effluent treatment plant (CETP); treatment, storage, and disposal facility (TSDF), water supply and distribution systems; solvent recovery and distillation facilities; steam generation and distribution network; interconnected pipeline network; and logistics and warehousing facilities.

The government noted that the establishment of three parks would make the Indian chemical industry globally competitive. “It will promote development of Indian chemical industry in a sustainable way by creating an environment-friendly ecosystem which will consist of centralized facilities...”

Forex stocks rise \$1.08 bn to \$676.237 bn



MUMBAI: India's forex reserves jumped by \$1.08 billion to \$676.237 billion during the week ended July 17, according to the RBI data released on Friday.

In the previous reporting week, the overall forex kitty had jumped by \$964 million to \$675.157 billion.

Forex reserves had expanded to an all-time high of \$728.494 billion during the week ended February 27 this year before the onset of the Middle East conflict, which led to several weeks of a drop as the rupee came under pressure and the RBI had to intervene in the forex market through dollar sales.

For the week ended July 17, foreign currency assets, a major component of the reserves, increased by \$4.549 billion to \$551.057 billion, the RBI's data showed.

Expressed in dollar terms, the foreign currency assets include effects of appreciation or depreciation of non-US units, such as the euro, pound, and yen, held in the forex reserves.

Value of gold reserves dropped by \$3.48 billion to \$101.749 billion during the week, the RBI said.

The Special Drawing Rights were up by \$44 million at \$18.67 billion, the RBI said. India's reserve position with the IMF was down by \$32 million to \$4.761 billion at the end of the reporting week, according to the RBI data.

‘Govt disburses ₹35,354 cr as on March 31 under PLI’

NEW DELHI: The government has disbursed Rs 35,354 crore to beneficiaries of the Production Linked Incentive (PLI) schemes as on March 31 this year, Parliament was informed in the Rajya Sabha on Friday.

The government has launched the PLI schemes in 2020 for 14 key sectors with an approved outlay of Rs 1.91 lakh crore to enhance India's manufacturing capabilities, attract investments, promote exports, generate employment and reduce import dependence.

In a written reply to the Rajya Sabha, Minister of State for Commerce and Industry Jitin Prasada said as “on March 31, 2026, under the PLI schemes, 892 applications have been approved across 14 sectors, resulting in actual investment of over Rs 2.40 lakh crore, production/sales of over Rs 22.66 lakh crore, exports of over Rs 15.2 lakh crore,



employment generation of over 14.15 lakh (direct and indirect) out of which 8.4 lakhs is Direct employment and cumulative incentive disbursement of Rs 35,354 crore”.

He said that the pharmaceuticals sector has recorded cumulative sales of over Rs 3.64 lakh crore under the scheme.

It has also enabled the domestic manufacture of 1,931 pharmaceutical products, including 191 bulk drugs manufactured in India for the first time, thereby strengthening domestic manufacturing capabilities, he added.

Stock markets extend losses for 5th straight day on US trade tariffs, West Asia tensions

MUMBAI: Market benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty ended lower on Friday, extending the losing streak for the fifth consecutive session, as investors remained cautious due to rising oil prices amid geopolitical tensions in West Asia and renewed concerns over US trade tariffs.

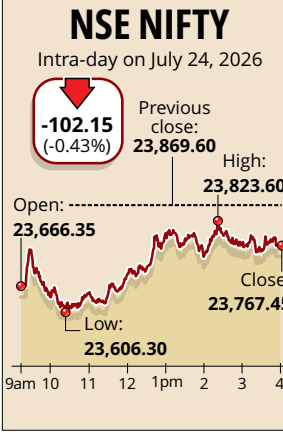
Fresh foreign fund outflows and selling in blue-chip HDFC Bank also dented market sentiment.

The 30-share BSE Sensex declined 331.62 points, or 0.43 per cent, to settle at 76,059.77. During the day, it tanked 916.96 points, or 1.20 per cent, to 75,474.43.

The 50-share NSE Nifty dipped 102.15 points, or 0.43 per cent, to end at 23,767.45.

From the Sensex pack, Eterna, Mahindra & Mahindra, Bajaj Finance, Bharti Airtel, Asian Paints and Infosys were among the major laggards.

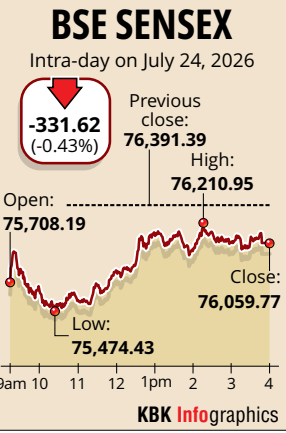
IT services company Info-



sys declined 1 per cent after it tempered the upper end of its full-year revenue forecast to between 1.5 per cent and 3 per cent amid continued macroeconomic uncertainty.

HCL Tech, ITC, Axis Bank and Tata Consultancy Services were among the winners.

Brent crude, the global oil



benchmark, dropped 3.66 per cent to \$96.98 per barrel on Friday, after surpassing \$100 per barrel in the previous session.

Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) offloaded equities worth Rs 2,999.23 crore on Thursday, according to exchange data.

The BSE MidCap Select

index climbed 0.46 per cent, while the SmallCap Select index edged higher by 0.08 per cent.

Among sectors, Auto declined 0.96 per cent, Telecommunication 0.90 per cent, Power 0.67 per cent, Consumer Discretionary 0.65 per cent, Oil & Gas 0.65 per cent, Realty 0.54 per cent, Metal 0.50 per cent and Energy 0.39 per cent.

Focused IT jumped 1.30 per cent, IT 0.66 per cent, PSU Bank 0.65 per cent, MidSmall Private Banks Quality Tilt 0.46 per cent, Insurance 0.43 per cent and FMCG 0.20 per cent.

In the last five trading days, the BSE benchmark tanked 2,091.68 points, or 2.67 per cent, and the Nifty declined 566.85 points, or 2.32 per cent.

On Thursday, the Sensex declined 363.66 points, or 0.47 per cent, to settle at 76,391.39. The Nifty dipped 126.65 points, or 0.53 per cent, to end at 23,869.60.

Rupee up 20 paise to 96.53 against dollar



MUMBAI: The rupee recovered 20 paise to close at 96.53 against the US dollar on Friday amid likely intervention by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI).

A combination of factors, including heightened tensions in West Asia, FII outflows, and sustained negative sentiments at the domestic equity markets, maintained pressure on the local unit, according to forex traders.

At the interbank foreign exchange, the rupee opened weaker at 96.81 and traded in the range of 96.30-96.81 before eventually settling at 96.53, up 20 paise from its previous close.

The rupee ended 20 paise weaker at 96.73 against the US dollar on Thursday.

“We expect the rupee to trade with a negative bias as on further escalation in tensions between the US and Iran. Elevated crude oil prices may also pressure the rupee. However, diplomatic talks between the two nations may prevent a sharp fall in the rupee,” Anuj Choudhary, Research Analyst, Mirae Asset ShareKhan, said.

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading marginally down by 0.06 per cent at 101.38.

MCF, Raebareli participates in 7th Rail & Metro Technology Conclave

NEW DELHI: The Modern Coach Factory (MCF), Raebareli, is showcasing its advanced coach manufacturing capabilities at the 7th Rail & Metro Technology Conclave & Expo 2026 being held at Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi from July 22-24.

The MCF pavilion features miniature coach models, audio-visual presentations & publicity material highlighting its technological advancements and contribution to the modernisation of Indian Railways.

Located at Stall M-136A, the pavilion has attracted industry representatives, rail-



way officials & visitors.

MCF said its participation aims to promote technological innovation, strengthen industry collaboration and support the Atmanirbhar Bharat initiative.

It also created awareness among MSMEs about registration on the Indian Railways E-Procurement System (IREPS) and business opportunities available through the platform.

REC Q1 profit rises 23% sequentially to ₹4,149 cr

NEW DELHI: State-owned REC Ltd on Friday reported a 23 per cent sequential rise in standalone net profit to Rs 4,149 crore for the June quarter of FY27, while net interest income (NII) increased 5 per cent to Rs 5,212 crore from Rs 4,961 crore in the preceding quarter.

The company maintained a net interest margin (NIM) of 3.34 per cent and reported an annualised earnings per share (EPS) of Rs 63.04.

Its standalone loan book stood at Rs 5.90 lakh crore as of June 30, the largest among CPUSU-NBFCs, while net worth rose 15 per cent year-on-year to

Rs 91,836 crore.

REC's renewable energy portfolio grew to Rs 78,596 crore, accounting for 13.32 per cent of total loans, while its infrastructure and logistics portfolio reached Rs 59,289 crore.

The Stage-3 loan ratio improved to 0.11 per cent, with the capital adequacy ratio remaining strong at 23.06 per cent against the Reserve Bank of India's 15 per cent requirement.

The Board of Directors of the Company has declared the First Interim Dividend of Rs 4.25 per equity share (face value Rs 10 each).

NEW DELHI: Jindal Steel Ltd on Friday announced the appointment of Vidya Rattan Sharma as the company's Managing Director for the second time. Sharma previously served as the Managing Director of Jindal Steel (erstwhile Jindal Steel & Power Ltd) from 2019 to 2022.

In an exchange filing, Jindal Steel said the board has approved his appointment as Additional Director and Managing Director of the company for a term of two years with effect from July 24, 2026, based on the recommendation of the Nomination and Remunera-



tion Committee and subject to approval of the shareholders.

He has also served as the Deputy Managing Director & Chief Executive Officer of JSPL from 2010 to 2014. He brings four decades of international leadership experience in the steel, power, metal and cement sectors.

The MD post fell vacant after the resignation of Gautam Malhotra with effect from July 15, 2026.

In the filing, the company further said its board has approved the appointment of Sandeep Modi as Chief Financial Officer of the company with effect from July 24, 2026.

Among others, Rajiv Kumar has been appointed as Chief Operating Officer (Senior Management Personnel), and Sukhjit S. Pasricha as Head - Human Resources (Senior Management Personnel) with effect from July 24, 2026.

‘OpenAI can use copyrighted material to train ChatGPT’

‘India is considered forerunner in AI & data is the oil for LLMs to work efficiently,’ Justice Amit Bansal said

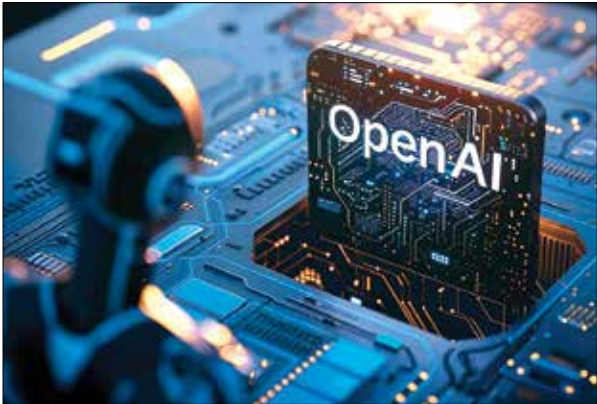
OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi High Court on Friday said AI has revolutionised how public seeks information and restraining ChatGPT from using copyrighted work would be detrimental to the growth of AI and LLMs being developed in the country.

Justice Amit Bansal said India is considered a forerunner in the field of AI and “data is the oil for ‘large language models’ (LLMs) to work efficiently”.

LLM refers to a language-focused AI model which can read, understand and generate text. Justice Bansal made the observations in an interim order passed on a lawsuit by news agency ANI against OpenAI, which runs the platform ChatGPT.

Holding that the use of ANI’s copyrighted literary work by ChatGPT amounted to fair dealing under the Copyrights Act, and did not amount to an infringement of its intellectual property right, the court dismissed an application by the news agency seeking an interim injunction against



ChatGPT. The court further said that any injunction at this stage would adversely impact public interest and millions of users of ChatGPT in India.

“AI, including generative AI, has brought about a transformational change in the lives of the people all over the world, including India. It has completely revolutionised the manner in which people seek and obtain information... Any interim injunction granted at this stage would, in my opinion, be detrimental to the growth of AI and more particularly, to the LLMs being developed

in India,” the court said in the order.

“I am of the prima facie view that OpenAI’s act of storing ANI’s original literary works for training LLMs underlying ChatGPT falls under Section 52(1)(a) of the Copyright Act and therefore, does not amount to infringement under Section 51 of the Copyright Act,” the court held. In the 135-page order, the court explained that training LLMs underlying ChatGPT advanced scientific knowledge, developed innovative computational tools, disseminated information, promoted

KEY POINTS

» ‘AI, including generative AI, has brought about a transformational change in the lives of the people all over the world,’ Justice Amit Bansal said

» ‘Any interim injunction would be detrimental to growth of AI and to LLMs being developed in India’

education, etc., and while the rights of copyright owners were important, the societal benefits arising from such scientific and technological research was a relevant factor.

“Therefore, on a prima facie view, from the above analysis, this court is of the view that the process of training LLMs underlying ChatGPT undertaken by Open AI using stored literary work of ANI falls under ‘private or personal use, including research’ as provided in Section 52(1)(a) of the Copyright Act and fulfils the ‘purpose’ test,” it stated.

SLOWEST PACE OF EXPANSION SINCE MARCH 2022

India private sector growth slows further in July: HSBC Flash PMI

NEW DELHI: India’s private sector growth slowed further in July, recording the weakest pace of expansion since March 2022, as challenging market conditions, competitive pressures and weaker demand weighed on business activity, according to the HSBC Flash PMI data report. The report said the HSBC Flash India PMI Composite Output Index fell to 54.3 in July from 57.1 in June, signalling the slowest pace of expansion in private sector activity since March 2022.

HSBC Flash India PMI Composite Output Index is a seasonally adjusted index that measures the month-on-month change in the combined output of India’s manufacturing and services sectors. It stated, “The HSBC Flash PMI data for July showed the weakest expansions in private sector sales and output since early 2022”.

However, the report also shared that the new export orders continued to grow at a stronger pace, firms kept hiring additional workers, and both input costs and output charges increased at a faster rate.

The report noted that growth was held back by increasingly challenging market conditions, competitive pressures, order



cancellations, reduced client enquiries and shortages of key raw materials. Although new orders continued to rise at the beginning of the second fiscal quarter, the pace of expansion eased to the weakest level in close to four-and-a-half years and remained moderate by historical standards.

The moderation in both output and new order growth was largely driven by the services sector, where the pace of expansion retreated significantly from June to the weakest level in 53 months. In contrast, the manufacturing sector regained some of the momentum it had lost in previous months.

The report said both manufacturing and services firms recorded stronger export growth during July, with goods producers outperforming service providers. The seasonally adjusted index for manufacturing exports rose by nearly four points, while at the composite level, international sales increased at the fastest pace since March.

Manufacturing-specific data also showed improvement in several areas. Companies increased their purchasing activity, while a further improvement in vendor performance supported faster growth in input inventories. After declining in

HIGHLIGHTS

» Moderation in both output & new order growth was largely driven by services sector, where pace of expansion retreated from June to weakest level in 53 months

» In contrast, the manufacturing sector regained some of the momentum it had lost in previous months

June, stocks of finished goods also increased during July.

Despite these improvements, the HSBC Flash India Manufacturing PMI edged down to 53.9 in July from 54.2 in June, indicating a below-trend improvement in overall factory conditions, the report said.

Overall, the report highlighted that while India’s manufacturing sector showed signs of resilience and export demand strengthened, slower growth in the services sector & softer domestic demand resulted in the weakest expansion in the country’s private sector activity.

ANI

Adani Enterprises denies plans to enter airline business

NEW DELHI: Adani Enterprises has denied media reports that it is planning to launch an airline, as per a statement by the company.

In the release, Adani noted, it is not evaluating any proposal to enter the airline business, calling the reports “entirely baseless and factually incorrect”.

“We would like to categorically deny the recent media reports and market speculation suggesting that Adani Enterprises is planning to launch an airline. These reports are

entirely baseless and factually incorrect,” it said.

It added, “Adani Enterprises is not evaluating any proposal to enter the airline business.”

Earlier media reports had stated that major airport operators GMR Group and Adani Group were seeking approval to enter the airline business by pursuing changes to existing rules governing airport operators’ ownership of scheduled airlines.

Media reports suggested that the move would require amendments to the existing



regulatory framework, which currently bars operators of the New Delhi and Mumbai airports from holding more than a 10 per cent stake in a scheduled airline. The reports further said the government was examining the possibility of amending the

provision, including seeking legal opinion, with any change requiring Cabinet approval.

However, neither the government nor the airport operators have officially announced any changes to the existing rules.

In a separate development, Adani Defence & Aerospace and the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) signed an agreement to develop India’s next-generation Airborne Early Warning & Control (AEW&C-MKII) system for the Indian Air Force

(IAF) to support PM Narendra Modi’s Aatmanirbhar Bharat initiative.

Under the agreement, the two organisations will jointly develop, manufacture and integrate airborne mission systems on six modified Airbus A321 aircraft for the IAF. The programme will also cover integrated logistics, maintenance, repair and overhaul (MRO), and technical support for up to 30 years. The AEW&C-MKII platforms are scheduled for induction into the IAF in 2032-33.

ANI

Hindustan Zinc June qtr net profit rises over two-fold to ₹5,469 crore

NEW DELHI: Vedanta group firm Hindustan Zinc Limited (HZL) on Friday reported over two-fold jump in consolidated net profit to Rs 5,469 crore for the quarter ended June 30, 2026 on the back of higher metal prices, and increased metal production.

The company had posted a net profit of Rs 2,234 crore in the corresponding quarter of the previous fiscal.

“During the quarter, net profit stood at Rs 5,469 crore,

up 145 per cent Year-on-Year,” Hindustan Zinc Limited said in a regulatory filing.

The revenue of Hindustan Zinc Limited rose by 71.6 per cent to Rs 13,033 crore during the first quarter over Rs 7,591 crore in the year-ago period.

The revenue from operations rose “driven by higher metal prices, increased metal production, lead concentrate sale, higher by-product realisation, and a

stronger dollar,” Hindustan Zinc Limited said.

The board also appointed former SAIL Chairman and Managing Director Amarendu Prakash as the Chief Executive Officer and Wholtime Director of Hindustan Zinc with effect from August 1, 2026.

The company further said that Amit Gupta has assumed the role of Chief Financial Officer of Hindustan Zinc Limited with effect from June 1.

MP0ST

Sport

Let the Games begin

Opening ceremony done, Indian athletes turn attention to pursuit of glory

S KANNAN

GLASGOW: It was a smart turnout by the Indian contingent at the 2026 Commonwealth Games opening ceremony on Thursday night, with King Charles and Queen Camilla in attendance. The dress designed for the males was elegant, while the ladies walked in a saree. High energy and focus on keeping the ceremony short highlighted the two-hour ceremony, as planned by the organisers.

What stood out, however, was the mood of Glasgow. Unlike other cities which host an Olympics and grapple with a lot of security problems and restrictions, Scotland’s largest city has offered a more relaxed and welcoming atmosphere.

The city has used existing infrastructure to host the Games and as it is located near the City Centre, athletes have been able to celebrate. Music, cafes, near the venues, all this makes Glasgow a throbbing city.

But then, for most Indian athletes, the celebration ‘hang-over’ was short-lived. By Friday morning, the Indian athletes had to hit the ground running. It was either training or back to first round events in various disciplines.



Artists perform during the opening ceremony at the OVO Hydro; BELOW: The Indian contingent march on

PTI

An important section of the contingent – track and field – trooped into Glasgow in batches from Spala, Poland, where they were training. Hopes of a medal from Neeraj Chopra are high this time. Neeraj had won gold at the 2018 edition of the CWG in Gold Coast. He missed the 2022 edition, but is raring to go this time.

For Lovlina Borgohain, work on Friday involved two hectic sessions. She is now competing in the 75kg cate-

gory, after winning her Olympics bronze medal in Tokyo in the 69-kg category.

Having received a bye on Thursday, she is now fully geared up. Speaking to the media on Friday, Lovlina was very happy. She was the flag and baton bearer with Mirabai Chanu at the opening ceremony.

Focus has shifted to the training sessions. With the weather in Glasgow changing everyday, Lovlina has to stay warm and train in earnest.



Lovlina targets gold

GLASGOW: With a medal already guaranteed before throwing a punch, India’s Lovlina Borgohain says the absence of podium pressure has freed her to chase the one prize she really wants at the Commonwealth Games -- gold.

The Tokyo Olympic bronze medallist advanced directly to the women’s 75kg semifinals after receiving a bye, assuring India of its first medal of the Games.

For a boxer who had to battle through multiple bouts in each of her previous Commonwealth Games campaigns without reaching the podium, the direct passage came as a surprise.

“This was shocking news even for me. I never thought I’d get a direct entry into the semifinal because in the last two Commonwealth Games, I didn’t even have a medal and I had to fight four or five bouts,” Lovlina said on Friday. “Maybe this is a blessing for all my hard work.”

AGENCIES

HARARE: On recovery path with their maiden win under new captain Shreyas Iyer, India will look to sustain the winning momentum for an unassailable lead against Zimbabwe when the two teams face off in the second T20I here on Saturday.

After being swept away by Ireland (0-2) and England (0-4), three-time T20 World Cup winners India produced a far better show in their series-opener here on Thursday, beating Zimbabwe by seven wickets to take a 1-0 lead.

Young batting sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi’s 19-ball 50 and Mayank Yadav’s fiery 4-0-18-2 set up an important win for India in the opening match here, against an opponent which has thrived in home conditions of late.

India chased down a modest 126 with more than six overs and seven wickets to spare, riding on Sooryavanshi’s fifty, a quickfire 35 from Ishan Kishan and a measured 28 not out from skipper Iyer.

Abhishek Sharma, who began his T20I journey here at the Harare Sports Club and struck his maiden hundred in the format in the second game itself two years ago, would be keen to make amends after falling cheaply in the opening game.



Shreyas Iyer and Tilak Varma after the first T20I

PTI

India appeared to have adapted well to the conditions

Sooryavanshi set the record for being the youngest to score a T20I half-century. The young batter would have been relieved getting the monkey off his back, especially when he was specifically targeted with short balls on England tour.

But more than their batters’ strong showing, the collective effort from a young pace attack would have pleased the team management, which has VVS Laxman in charge as the head coach for this series.

India appeared to have

adapted well to the conditions as Prince Yadav claimed 2/29 in a much-improved performance, while the debutant Ashok Sharma also cranked up high pace even though he remained wicket-less.

But the biggest takeaway was a successful return to top flight cricket for right-arm pacer Mayank, who spent nearly two years on the sidelines with a string of injuries since making his debut. Extra pace had a role to play in his second wicket as Dion Myers (6) failed to time his pull shot in the fifth over. Mayank’s pace as well as control was top notch in the opener, with the dismissal of Zimbabwe batting mainstay Brian Bennett on a delivery that shaped away.

AGENCIES

Whereabouts failure costs judoka Tulika CWG spot

NEW DELHI: Birmingham Commonwealth Games silver medal-winning judoka Tulika Maan has been withdrawn from the ongoing Glasgow edition after being handed a provisional suspension by the National Anti-Doping Agency (NADA) for three whereabouts failures in the last 12 months.

Maan had won silver in the +78kg category in the 2022 edition and she was a strong medal prospect in Glasgow as



well. She now stares at a two-year ban. “She has committed three whereabouts failures in a 12-month period and NADA

has sent notice to her. So, she will be withdrawn from the team,” a judo coach told PTI on conditions of anonymity.

The 27-year-old from Delhi is the second judoka to have been withdrawn from Glasgow CWG. On Thursday, Arun Kumar, who competes in the men’s -73kg category, was pulled out of the Games after failing an out-of-competition dope test. He was handed a provisional suspension by the

NADA for testing positive for an anabolic steroid.

Maan is one of the most accomplished judokas in the country. She had represented the country in the 2024 Paris Olympics where she made an exit in the round of 32. She also took part in the 2022 and 2024 World Championships.

The Indian judo team has not yet left for the Games as its competition schedule will kick off on July 31.

AGENCIES

NORTHERN RAILWAY TENDER NOTICE Sub-: NIT No. 30-DyCEE-GSU-DLI-26-27 The Dy. Chief Electrical Engineer/Gait Shakti Unit/Delhi, DRM Office, New Delhi-110055 invites e-tender for the following work:	
1.	Name of Work and Location : Balance Electrical Work of Lighting and Power Supply arrangement for MSZ, JIND, ROK, BGZ, SNP and other Railway Stations of DLI Division under Amrit Bharat Scheme
2.	Tender Notice No. : 30-DyCEE-GSU-DLI-26-27
3.	Earnest Money Amount (to be deposited online) : Rs. 5,79,600.00/-
4.	Approximate Cost : Rs. 2,89,81,825.85/-
5.	Date & Time for Submission of e-Tender and Opening of Tender : Tenders uploaded on date 24.07.2026 on IREPS website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in . The bidders can participate in the e-tender, the tender will be opened at 11:30 Hrs. on 17.08.2026.
6.	Detailed Tender Notice & Tender Document : The detailed e-tender notice is available on Northern Railway website i.e. www.nr.indianrailways.gov.in and tender document is available on www.ireps.gov.in . Above tender document will be available for submission of offer on IREPS website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in from 02.08.2026 to 17.08.2026. All other terms and conditions in respect of the above tenders are given in tender document. The detailed tender notice also can be seen on the Notice Board at the above office.

For and on behalf of the President of India, Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager/G, Delhi Division, Northern Railway invites applications in the prescribed format from renowned and eligible manufacturers/suppliers/firms for supplementary shortlisting of PAD/Non-PAD items/brands for sale/supply at catering establishments over Delhi Division, Northern Railway for the validity period up to 31.03.2027. Applications for supplementary shortlisting may be submitted in the office of Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager/G, Northern Railway, State Entry Road, New Delhi during working hours between 10:00 hrs and 17:00 hrs on any working day up to 31.12.2026 (15:00 hrs). The notified period shall be extended upto 31.03.2027 for the purpose of supplementary shortlisting. The brands/items shortlisted under this supplementary shortlisting shall remain valid up to 31.03.2027 and shall be governed by the terms and conditions of the notification. Detailed notification, eligibility criteria, terms & conditions and application form are available on Northern Railway website i.e. <https://nr.indianrailways.gov.in>. Any corrigendum/modification, if any, shall be available on the aforesaid website only. 2545/2026

See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Sandeep Kumar S/o Om Prakash R/o G 159A, G-Block, Naveen Vihar Colony, Rajeev Nagar Extn Begumpur, Delhi** has Committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 585/2016 U/s 279/338/304A IPC, P.S. Shahbad Dairy, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Sandeep Kumar** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Sandeep Kumar** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Sandeep Kumar** of case **FIR No. 585/2016 U/s 279/338/304A IPC, P.S. Shahbad Dairy, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **08.09.2026**.

See Section 82 (ii) Cr. P.C.

Whereas a complaint has been made before me that accused person namely **Aas Mohd S/o Pappu R/o H.No. 649, Gali No. 10, Block-12, Sangam Vihar, Delhi**, have committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence under **case FIR No. 556/2016 U/s 363/317 IPC.**, has been registered at **PS: Sangam Vihar, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said, **Aas Mohd** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said, **Aas Mohd** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused, **Aas Mohd** under **case FIR No. 556/2016 U/s 363/317 IPC.**, registered at **PS: Sangam Vihar, New Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **02.09.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Chatinder Singh
JMFC-04 (South)

DP/9859/SD/2026
(Court Notice) **Saket Court Complex, New Delhi**

<u>E-PROCUREMENT TENDER NOTICE</u>				
On behalf of the President of India, The Principal Chief Materials Manager, North Central Railway, Prayagraj, (An ISO 9001:2015 certified unit) invites the following E-procurement Tenders.				
S. N.	Tender No.	Short Description	Qty.	Tender Opening Date
1	20263488	Set of Labyrinth and Bearing cap & clamp plate	651 Set.	24.08.2026
2	90262364	STRAIGHTENED SPRING STEEL ROUND RODS (PEELED BAR) TO SIZE 40 MM DIAMETER x 3730 MM LONG	763.5 MT	12.08.2026
3	90262365	STRAIGHTENED SPRING STEEL ROUND RODS (PEELED BAR) TO SIZE 27 MM DIAMETER x 3260 MM LONG	270.05 MT	13.08.2026
4	38262757	DOOR ARRANGEMENT FOR BOBKN WAGON	2575 Nos	19.08.2026
5	30262306	BRAKE CYLINDER [LEFT VERSION]	44 NOS.	13.08.2026
6	40261634	Lead Acid Battery	56 Set.	20.08.2026

Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi-110005
PUBLIC NOTICE:
Builder Cancellation

This is to bring to your notice that Rohit Sharma/ Pramod Kumar Sharma (borrower/s) has availed Home loan facility vide facility agreement number LBDEL00002086511 located at Flat No B-1406 14th Floor, Snowberry Tower Greenarch, Plot No. Gh-10a Sector- Tehzone-iv, Greater Noida (West) Noida-2120307. The borrower/s has failed to pay the contractual amount to the builder as per the terms and conditions of the agreement.

The Bank had informed the same to the borrower through letter dated July 23, 2026, informing that New Way Homes Pvt. Ltd, has cancelled the allotment of the above mentioned property. You are therefore requested to resolve this matter with the builder within 7 days from the date of this publication.

Please take further notice that post cancellation of the allotment of the said property ICICI Bank shall not be bound and/or responsible for any other allotment done by the builder.

Dated: July 25, 2026
Place : Delhi/NCR

For ICICI Bank Limited
Sd-

SHO P/S Domana, Jammu has intimated that accused person namely Manik S/O Raj Singh R/O H. No. 58 Sec-9, Nanak Nagar, Jammu is evading his arrest/wanted in case FIR No. 44/2009 U/S 379/147/148/427 RPC of P/S Domana, since the commission of crime. Despite repeated raids/efforts the accused could not be traced/still absconded.

It is therefore requested that Hue and Cry Notice of above mentioned accused is being published for the information of Police establishments / Public in general having any clue related to the whereabouts / present location of above named accused, kindly communicate the same on the below mentioned contact / Telephone numbers.

Description Roll :-

Name	: Manik
S/O	: Raj Singh
Address	: H. No. 58 Sec-9, Nanak Nagar, Jammu

Contacts/Telephone Numbers:-

1.DPO, Jammu	:0191-2547807,0191-2561578
2.SSP Jammu Mail I.D	: ssjpjammu@kpolice.gov.in
3.PCR Jammu	:0191-2605949
4.SP Rural	:0191-2605949
5. SDPO Domana	:0191-2604220
6.P/S Domana	:0191-2604214

Sd/-
Sr. Superintendent of Police
Jammu

DIP No:DIP/J-6579/26

JAMMU AND KASHMIR POLICE <u>DISTRICT POLICE HEADQUARTERS JAMMU</u> 0191-2561578 (O), 0191-254780 (F), email-sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in Hue and Cry Notice Rule No. 712/191																						
SHO P/S Nowabad, Jammu has intimated that accused person namely Krishan Lal @ Dabu S/O Sant Ram R/O Janipur evading his arrest/wanted in case FIR No. 38/1984 U/S 379/34 RPC of P/S Nowabad, since the commission of crime. Despite repeated raids/efforts the accused could not be traced/still absconded. It is therefore requested that Hue and Cry Notice of above mentioned accused is being published for the information of Police establishments / Public in general having any clue related to the whereabouts / present location of above named accused, kindly communicate the same on the below mentioned contact / Telephone numbers.																						
Description Roll :- <table border="0"> <tr> <td>Name</td> <td>:</td> <td>Krishan Lal @ Dabu</td> </tr> <tr> <td>S/O</td> <td>:</td> <td>Sant Ram</td> </tr> <tr> <td>Address</td> <td>:</td> <td>Janipur</td> </tr> </table>		Name	:	Krishan Lal @ Dabu	S/O	:	Sant Ram	Address	:	Janipur												
Name	:	Krishan Lal @ Dabu																				
S/O	:	Sant Ram																				
Address	:	Janipur																				
Contacts/Telephone Numbers:- <table border="0"> <tr> <td>1.DPO, Jammu</td> <td>:</td> <td>0191-2547807,</td> </tr> <tr> <td>0191-2561578</td> <td>:</td> <td></td> </tr> <tr> <td>2. SSP Jammu Mail I.D</td> <td>:</td> <td>sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in</td> </tr> <tr> <td>3.PCR Jammu</td> <td>:</td> <td>0191-2605949</td> </tr> <tr> <td>4.SP City North</td> <td>:</td> <td>0191-2547038</td> </tr> <tr> <td>5.Dy. SP Hqrs.</td> <td>:</td> <td>0191-2562259</td> </tr> <tr> <td>6.PS Nowabad</td> <td>:</td> <td>0191-2565274</td> </tr> </table>		1.DPO, Jammu	:	0191-2547807,	0191-2561578	:		2. SSP Jammu Mail I.D	:	sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in	3.PCR Jammu	:	0191-2605949	4.SP City North	:	0191-2547038	5.Dy. SP Hqrs.	:	0191-2562259	6.PS Nowabad	:	0191-2565274
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5.Dy. SP Hqrs.	:	0191-2562259																				
6.PS Nowabad	:	0191-2565274																				
Sd/- Sr. Superintendent of Police Jammu																						
DIP No/DIP/J-6589/26																						

Rule No. 712/191

SHO P/S Nowabad, Jammu has intimated that accused person namely Nisar Ahmed S/O Gh. Rasool Wani R/O Pampore, Kashmir is evading his arrest/wanted in case FIR No. 251/1992 U/S 3/25 A.Act, 4/SEC 3 TATA Act of P/S Nowabad, since the commission of crime. Despite repeated raids/efforts the accused could not be traced/still absconded.

It is therefore requested that Hue and Cry Notice of above mentioned accused is being published for the information of Police establishments / Public in general having any clue related to the whereabouts / present location of above named accused, kindly communicate the same on the below mentioned contact / Telephone numbers.

Description Roll :-

Name	:	Nisar Ahmed
S/O	:	Gh. Rasool Wani
Address	:	Pampore, Kashmir

Contacts/Telephone Numbers:-

1.DPO, Jammu	:0191-2547807,
0191-2561578	
2. SSP Jammu Mail I.D	: ssppjammu@jkpolice.gov.in
3.PCR Jammu	:0191-2605949
4.SP City North	: 0191-2547038
5.Dy. SP Hqrs	..0191-2562259
6.PS Nowabad	: 0191-2565274

Sd/-

Sr. Superintendent of Police
Jammu

DIP No:DIP/J-6592/26

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

CREDA invites online tender for standardization of rates for Supply, Installation, and Commissioning of low maintenance lead acid (LMLA), T-gel & Lithium Ferro Phosphate (LiFePO4) batteries of different capacities with five years on-site warranty conforming to the BIS & MNRE standards anywhere in the state of Chhattisgarh from registered battery vendors (Manufacturer or Dealer/Distributor of Battery manufacturer) of CREDA having experience of supply of batteries with 3 years track record in the field of manufacturing and supply of batteries.

Inspection of Sample : 06.08.2026 at 12:00 PM
Last date of submission of Online Bid : 13.08.2026 till 5:00 PM
Opening of Online Bid : 17.08.2026 12:00 PM onwards

Technical Bid and Price Bid shall be submitted online only at <https://gem.gov.in> Bidders are advised to follow the instructions provided for Registration and e-Submission Process accordingly in the Gem Portal. (For any query about e-bidding please visit user manual at <https://gem.gov.in>).

Tender document with all terms and conditions is available at www.creda.co.in and at <https://gem.gov.in>

CREDA reserves all rights to accept/reject any or all tenders in full/part without assigning any reasons.

samvad 48554/3

Chief Engineer
CREDA

See Section 82 Cr. P.C./ 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Aman Kumar S/o Bikat Pal R/o Near NDPL Office, Nangli Puna, Swaroop Nagar, Delhi** has Committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 374/2022 U/s 279/338 IPC, P.S. Swaroop Nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Aman Kumar** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Aman Kumar** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Aman Kumar** of case **FIR No. 374/2022 U/s 279/338 IPC, P.S. Swaroop Nagar, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **17.09.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Sahil Gupta
Judicial Magistrate First Class-07
North, Court No. 6, Ground Floor
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/10109/ON/2026 (Court Matter)

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-TENDERING TENDER NOTICE

Divisional Railway Manager (Works) / N.C. Railway, Jhansi for and behalf of
 President of India invites sealed " Open Tender" through on Line (E-
 Tendering) for the following work.

Tender No.: JHS-ENGG-E-2026-178

Description of work: In-situ welding of rails by Alumino-Thermic Process by
 supply of Contractor's own RDSO approved welding portions under Jurisdiction
 of Sr.DENE/JHS

Approx Cost : 10865645.92	Earnest Money: 217300.00
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Period of completion/period from issue acceptance letter : 12 Months

Time of closing Tender : 18.08.2026 at 15:00 hrs. ● Tender online can be
 submitted up to 15:00 hrs on 18.08.2026. ● For full details and submission of bid
 please see the Indian Railways website www.irps.gov.in 1686(26/D)

www.northernrailways.gov.in
www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in
[@ CPNCRN](https://cpnrcr.com)

E-TENDER NOTICE
The Divisional Railway Manager (Engg.), C. Railway, Samastipur for and on behalf of the President of India invites Open Tender on experienced and financially capable bidders for the following works in e-tendering mode of IREPS web portal of Indian Railways:-

Tender Notice No: TC-104-2026-SPJ
Name of Work: Providing Pathway, Catchment, Pump Room, Shed Requiring, pump Cleaning, Dewatering etc. at LHS No. A, 11, 12, 13C, 20AC, 27AC, 30C in jurisdiction of SSUP/AMSP/SPJ. **Tender Value:** Rs. 2,32,20,151.06/- **Earnest Money:** Rs. 4,64,500.00/- **Completion Period:** 06 Months

Tender Notice No: TC-105-2026-SPJ
Name of Work: Providing Pathway, Catchment, Pump Room, Shed Requiring, pump Cleaning, Dewatering etc. at LHS No. A, 11, 12, 5B, 3A, 3B in jurisdiction of SE/W/IS/SPJ. **Tender Value:** Rs. 2,30,70,151.06/- **Earnest Money:** Rs. 4,61,400.00/- **Completion Period:** 06 Months

Tender Notice No: TC-106-2026-SPJ
Name of Work: Maintenance of new track Assets of Supaul- Amha Pipra - Triveniganj. **Tender Value:** Rs.1,19,138,825.25/- **Earnest Money:** Rs. 2,39,200.00/- **Completion Period:** 06 Months

Tender Notice No: TC-107-2026-SPJ
Name of Work: Provision of High Level Platform at PF-1 at Murliganj with all amenities including Divyanganj amenities as per norms. **Tender Value:** Rs.1,99,59,892.40/- **Earnest Money:** Rs. 3,99,200.00/- **Completion Period:** 06 Months

Tender Notice No: TC-108-2026-SPJ
Name of Work: Improvement of colony drainage, approach roads, boundary walls, repair drain near washing pit etc. at Dhanbad under jurisdiction of DEN/IS/SPJ. **Tender Value:** Rs. 4,43,28,806.44/- **Earnest Money:** Rs. 8,86,600.00/- **Completion Period:** 06 Months **Last Date & Time for receiving Tender in E-Tender mode on IREPS web portal:** 13/08/2026 upto 12:00 hours

Opening Date & Time for E-tender: 30/08/2026 after 12:00 hours. **Website particulars where complete details of tender & tender document can be seen in Website:** www.ireps.gov.in. Amendments/modifications if any shall not be published in the newspapers but the same shall be uploaded in the website.

Sr. Divisional Engineer/Co-ord E.C. Railway, Samastipur
OR/0606/SPJ/ENG/T/26-27/68

Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer (General)
East Central Railway, Dhanbad
PR/016/DHN/ELECT/T/26-27/68

FOR DIFFERENT ELECTRICAL WORKS OPEN TENDER FOR ELECTRICAL (GENERAL)
DRM (Electrical) / ECR / Dhanbad for and on behalf of the President of India invites e-Tender for execution of the following works.

e-Tender No.: EL/05/OPEN/2026-27 to EL/08/OPEN/2026-27

e-Tender No.: EL/05/OPEN/2026-27

1. Name of work with location and Completion of work: Hiring of Air Conditioning machines for different running rooms, Training School in Dhanbad Division for five years, (Completion period: 60 Months).
2. Approx cost of the work: Rs. 4345784.55/-
3. Bid Security to be deposited: Rs. 86900/-

e-Tender No.: EL/06/OPEN/2026-27

1. Name of work with location and Completion of work: Repairing of High Mast Tower at different stations in Dhanbad Division, (Completion period: 12 Months)
2. Approx cost of the work: Rs. 3031448.34/-
3. Bid Security to be deposited: Rs. 60600/-

e-Tender No.: EL/07/OPEN/2026-27

1. Name of work with location and Completion of work: Provision of street lighting arrangement with new cable laying at ROB/GOM in place of defective solar lights, (Completion period: 12 Months)
2. Approx cost of the work: Rs. 2199895.12/-
3. Bid Security to be deposited: Rs. 44000/-

e-Tender No.: EL/08/OPEN/2026-27

1. Name of work with location and Completion of work: Improvement in lighting & fanage system at yard side of Railway stations (57 Nos) in Dhanbad division, (Completion period: 12 Months)
2. Approx cost of the work: Rs. 20407824.16/-
3. Bid Security to be deposited: Rs. 408200.00/-

All e-Tender Bid Evaluation System/Single Pack

5. All Date & Time for submission of closing and opening of E-Tender: Closing of Bid On 14.08.2026 at 11:00 hrs., Opening of Bid On 14.08.2026 after 11:30 hrs
6. Website particulars: **W E B S I T E** www.ireps.gov.in, Manual offers are not allowed against e-tender.

Sale Notice for sale of immovable Property

Reconstruction Sale Notice for sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (SARFESI Act) read with proviso to Rule 8(6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower/s and Guarantor/s that the below described Immovable Property mortgaged to **Samman Capital Limited** (formerly known as Indiabulls Housing Finance Ltd.) [CIN : **U65922DL2005PLN3136029**] ("**Secured Creditor**"), the physical possession of which was taken by the Authorised Officer of the Secured Creditor, will be sold on "**as is where is**", "**as is what is**" and "**whatever there is**" basis on **27.08.2026** from **05.00 PM** to **06.00 PM**, for recovery of **Rs. 23,23,730/-** (**Rupees Twenty Three Lakhs Twenty Three Thousand Seven Hundred Thirty only**) i. e. **Rs. 22,05,961/-** (**Rupees Twenty Two Lakhs Five Thousand Nine Hundred Sixty One only**) pending towards **Loan Account No. HLLAJA00516435** and **Rs. 1,77,769/-** (**Rupees One Lakh Seventeen Thousand Seven Hundred Sixty Nine only**) pending towards **Loan Account No. HHELLAJ00516437**, by way of outstanding principal, arrears (including accrued late charges) and interest till **20.07.2026** with applicable future interest in terms of the Loan Agreement and other related loan document/s) w. e. f. **21.07.2026** along with legal expenses and other charges due to the Secured Creditor from **PANKAJ SINGH** and **JYOTI**.

The Reserve Price of the Immovable Property will be **Rs. 15,50,000/-** (**Rupees Fifteen Lakh Fifty Thousand only**) and the Earnest Money Deposit ("**EMD**") will be **Rs. 1,55,000/-** (**Rupees One Lakh Fifty Five Thousand only**) i. e. equivalent to 10% of the Reserve Price.

DESCRIPTION OF THE IMMOVABLE PROPERTY

ALL THAT PIECES OR PARCELS OF LAND / PROPERTIES AS UNDER TOGETHER WITH ALL THE PRESENT AND / OR FUTURE STRUCTURES, BUILDINGS, FURNITURE, FIXTURES, FITTINGS, STANDINGS, OR FUTURE RIGHTS, TITLE AND / OR INTERESTS OF MORTGAGORS THEREIN;

FLAT NO. SF 3, HAVING COVERED AREA OF 550 SQ. FT. I. E. 51.09 SQ. MTRS., ON THE 2ND FLOOR, WITH ROOF RIGHT, REAR LEFT HAND SIDE, CONSTRUCTED ON PLOT NO. A 7/5, DLF ANKUR VIHAR, LONI, DISTRICT SHAHAZAD - 201012, UTTAR PRADESH.

For detailed terms and conditions of sale, please refer to the link provided on the website of the Secured Creditor i.e. www.sammancapital.com; Contact No : 0124-19910910, 91 7065451024; E-mail id : auctionhelpline@sammancapital.com. For bidding, log on to www.auctionfocus.in.

sd/-
AUTHORIZED OFFICER
SAMMAN CAPITAL LIMITED
(Formerly known as
INDIABULLS HOUSING FINANCE LTD.)

Date : 20.07.2026
Place : GHAZIABAD

DESCRIPTION OF THE IMMOVABLE PROPERTY	
FLAT NO. SF. 3, M. I. G., HAVING TOTAL COVERED AREA OF 45 SQ. MTRS., SECOND FLOOR, WITHOUT ROOF RIGHTS, BACK SIDE (LHS), PLOT NO. 3/92S, SECTOR-14, VASUNDHARA, GHAZIABAD - 201012, UTTAR PRADESH.	
BOUNDED BY :	
EAST :	COMMON PASSAGE AND FLAT NO. S. F. 4
WEST :	OTHERS PROPERTY
NORTH :	PLOT NO. S. F. 2
SOUTH :	PLOT NO. 3/92N
For detailed terms and conditions of sale, please refer to the link provided on the website of the Secured Creditor i.e. www.sammancapital.com; Contact No : 01224-6810610/ 011705651024; E-mail id : auctionhelpline@sammancapital.com. For bidding, log on to www.auctionfocus.in.	
sd/- AUTHORIZED OFFICER SAMMAAN CAPITAL LIMITED (Formerly known as INDIABULLS HOUSING FINANCE LTD.)	
Date : 20.07.2026	
Place : GHAZIABAD	

APPENDIX IV-A
Sale Notice for sale of Immovable Property

E-Auction Sale Notice for sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to 8(6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

The undersigned, **Secured Creditor**, hereby gives notice to the **Secured Debtor** and the **Secured Debtor's** and **Guarantor(s)** that the **Secured Debtor** has described **Immovable Property mortgaged to the Secured Creditor** as **Secured Debtor's** **Immovable Property** mortgaged to the **Secured Creditor** as **Secured Creditor** and **Reconstruction Enterprise Ltd. [CIN : U65993DL2002PLC115769] ("Secured Creditor")**, the physical possession of which has been taken by the **Authorised Officer of the Secured Creditor**, will be sold on "as is where is", "as is where stands" basis on 31.08.2026 from 05.00 P.M. to 05.00 P.M., for recovery of **Rs. 25,59,542/- (Rupees Twenty Five Lakh Sixty Nine Thousand Five Hundred Forty Two only)**, pending towards **Loan Account No. HHLKUN00462978**, by way of outstanding principal, arrears (including accrued late charges) and interest till **03.06.2026** with applicable future interest in terms of the **Loan Agreement** and other related loan documents dated **31.04.06.2026** along with legal expenses and other charges due to the **Secured Creditor** from **JITENDER GARG, BRIJ LATA AND RAHUL GARG**.

The above-mentioned **Loan Account** along with all right(s), title(s), interest(s), underlying security(ies), pledge(s) and / or guarantee(s), including the **Immovable Property** mortgaged to the **Secured Creditor** as **Secured Debtor's** **Immovable Property** as **Indiabulls Housing Finance Ltd.** and in favour of the **Secured Creditor**, acting as a **Trustee of ACRE - 102 - Trust**, vide Assignment Agreement dated **27.06.2023**.

The Reserve Price of the **Immovable Property** will be **Rs. 22,00,000/- (Rupees Twenty Two Lakh Only)** and the **Earnest Money Deposit ("EMD")** will be **Rs. 22,00,000/- (Rupees Twenty Two Lakh Twenty Thousand only)**, i.e. equivalent to 10% of the **Reserve Price**.

LOT 10: TUMAC CITY, KUNDLI, SONEPARI - 131001, HARYANA.
 For detailed terms and conditions of the sale, please refer to the link provided below:
<https://www.auctioneersindia.com/Asset-Care-Reconstruction-Enterprise-Ltd-1234-6910310>
 or +91 7065451024; E-mail id: auctionhelper@sammanancapital.com. For bidding, log on
 to www.auctioneersindia.com.

	Sd/-
	AUTHORIZED OFFICER
Date : 23.07.2026	ASSETS CARE & RECONSTRUCTION ENTERPRISE LTD.
Place : SONEPARI	TRUSTEE OF ACARE - 102 - TRUST

"For any grievance you may contact Mr. Mohd Shariq Malik, Grievance
 Redressal Officer, Phone No. : 1800-209-2989, E-mail : complaint@acreindia.in.
 The policy of the company on Grievance Redressal Mechanism in the organisation
 can be accessed at <https://www.acreindia.in/compliance/>."

Tender Notice No: 5720262027	Date : 22.07.2026
E-Tender Notice	
Divisional Railway Manager (Engineering) / North Central Railway / Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites the following E-Tenders on prescribed form for the following works up to 13:30 hrs. on 19.08.2026. The details of the tenders are as under:	
S.N.1: 1 Tender No: 125, Name of Work: Improvement of level crossings (08 nos.) by rubberized surface in the section of Sr.DEN/III/PRYJ.	
Approx. Cost of Work (₹): 1,60,10,454.37	Bid Security (₹): ₹ 3,20,200.00
Completion Period: 06 months	Date of Opening of tender: 19.08.2026
S.N.2: 2 Tender No: 126, Name of Work: Improvement of colony road at Etawah and provision of sewer line at Etawah railway colony under ADEN/ETW.	
Approx. Cost of Work (₹): 4,84,86,638.54	Bid Security (₹): ₹ 9,69,700.00
Completion Period: 10 months	Date of Opening of tender: 19.08.2026
S.N.3: 3 Tender No: 127, Name of Work: Combined Tender: (A). Improvement of platform Surface of PF-3/4 at SKB station under ADEN/FZD. (B). Raising of Platform no. 2/3 up to high level for recoupment of shortfall in Minimum Essential Amenities (MEA) at MNR station under ADEN/FZD.	
Approx. Cost of Work (₹): 3,87,75,882.86	Bid Security (₹): ₹ 7,75,500.00
Completion Period: 09 months	Date of Opening of tender: 19.08.2026
Similar work for Eligibility Criteria: For S. N. 1:- Any work involving supply and fixing of rubberized surface on Roads or Railway level crossing. S. N. 2 & 3:- Any Civil Engineering Work.	
Note: (1) The complete information along with tender document of above E-Tenders is available on website www.irps.gov.in up to 13:30 hrs. on the due date of tender opening i.e. 19.08.2026. The tender shall be opened at or after 15:00 hrs on due date of opening. (2) Bids other than in the form of E-Bids shall not be accepted against above Tenders. For this purpose, vendors are required to get themselves registered with IRPS website along with Digital Signature Certificates issued by CCA under IT Act-2000. (3) Rates entered into Financial Rate page and duly signed digitally shall be considered. Rates and any other financial entity in any other form/letter head if attached by vendors shall be straightaway ignored and shall not be considered. (4) Tender No. 125 to 127 are having advertised value more than 50 Lakhs, therefore, Annexure-V & V(A) (Document Verification Certificate) is required. The supplier / contractor of goods and / or services would be subject to GST Act and Rules as applicable from time to time. (5) This tender notice has also been uploaded on www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in (6) In case of any difficulty/helpdesk available on the website of IRPS may be approached. (7) Tender online can be submitted up to 13:30 hrs. on 19.08.2026. (8) E-Tender Forms shall be issued free of cost to all tenders. (9) For tender no. 125 to 127 The tenders have to submit necessary documents in compliance of clause 10 to 18 (Part-I) of IRGCC-2022 (Works matter) mandatorily, otherwise their offer will be considered as Incomplete Offer and accordingly shall not be considered. 16902626 (MG)	
ncprncr@ncr.indianrailways.gov.in www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in	

Divisional Railway Manager (Works) N.C. Railway, Jhansi for and behalf of President of India invites sealed "Open Tender" through on Line (E-Tendering) for the following work.	
E-Tender No. : JHS-ENGG-N-2026-165	
Description of work : Shifting of OHE depot and Tower wagon siding from DHO to MRA for better mobility of Tower wagon/staff.	
Approx Cost : 37638417.53	Earnest Money : 752800.00
Date of closing Tender : 14/08/2026 at 15:00 hrs.	
Date of completion/period from issue acceptance letter : 12 Months.	
E-Tender No. : JHS-ENGG-N-2026-166	
Description of work : Part-A :- Provision of 5.00 KM RCC boundary wall along the track on approaches of Gwalior station at AGC end in main line under ADN/GWL. Part-B :- Provision of 5.00 KM RCC boundary wall along the track on approaches of Gwalior station at VGLJ end in main line under ADN/GWL..	
Approx Cost : 82388617.96	Earnest Money : 1647800.00
Date of closing Tender : 14/08/2026 at 15:00 hrs.	
Date of completion/period from issue acceptance letter : 12 Months.	
E-Tender No. : JHS-ENGG-N-2026-177	
Description of work : Cleaning of sewer lines and manholes etc in the jurisdiction of SSE/Wks/ML/GWL & SSE/Wks/NG/GWL under Sr. ADN/GWL for 02 years period.	
Approx Cost : 1920501.60	Earnest Money : 38400.00
Date of closing Tender : 14/08/2026 at 15:00 hrs.	
Date of completion/period from issue acceptance letter : 24 Months.	
* Tender online can be submitted upto to 15:00 hrs on 14.08.2026 . For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.reps.gov.in 1684262 (AS)	
📍 North central railway 📍 www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in 📍 @ CPRONC	



RANBIR KAPOOR FELT 'FEAR' PLAYING LORD RAMA

He said that 'Ramayana' will be his daughter Raha's first movie to see him as Lord Rama

Ranbir Kapoor and Yash offered fresh insights into their much-awaited film 'Ramayana' during the film's panel discussion at the San Diego Comic-Con 2026, where they were joined by director Nitesh Tiwari and producer Namit Malhotra. While the event was expected to culminate with the global launch of the film's trailer, the makers announced a last-minute postponement after securing 'Sony Pictures Entertainment' as the film's international distribution partner. The 'Ramayana' trailer was expected to be unveiled globally at 8 am on July 24, shortly after the Comic-Con panel. However, producer Namit Malhotra announced on 'Instagram' that the launch had been deferred. "Today is a very special moment for our 'Ramayana'. My dream of taking 'Ramayana' to the world is now a reality with our partnership with Sony Pictures Entertainment. In light of the above, we will be launching our



think that doubt changed into gratitude very early on. I think it was a blessing, an opportunity of a lifetime, and a moral responsibility. The Ramayana is ingrained in our subconscious. Lord Rama is the conscience keeper of millions of people around the world for generations, for more than 4000 years. He is somebody who embodies the triumph of the human spirit in times of adversity. He stands for courage, compassion, forgiveness, righteousness, and just to have the opportunity to represent that is very daunting." The actor said he soon realised that portraying one of mythology's most revered figures required sincerity and conviction. "Very early on, I understood that it just requires a lot of faith, a lot of belief, a lot of truthfulness and noble intentions. Our entire cast and crew had one noble intention and that is to tell the story as authentically as we can," he added.

The makers confirmed that 'Sony Pictures Entertainment' will distribute the film internationally

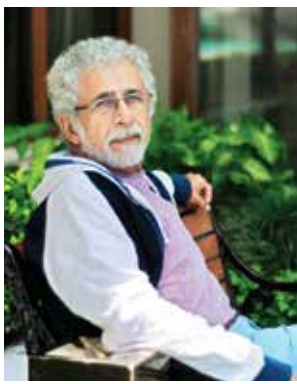
trailer now globally at a later date," he wrote. The announcement came after the makers confirmed that 'Sony Pictures Entertainment' will distribute the film internationally. On the sidelines of the Comic-Con event, Ranbir Kapoor spoke about taking on the role of Lord Rama, admitting that his first reaction was one of fear. "I remember when the film was first offered to me, there was so much of fear, so much of

doubt. 'Will I be able to do this, am I capable enough?' But I

AGENCIES

'A dog with a bone can't bark'

Naseeruddin Shah, who has been vocal about his support for the ongoing Cockroach Janta Party protests in New Delhi, called out the Bollywood film industry for their silence on the matter. In a recent interview, the veteran actor sharply criticised the actors in the industry, likening their silence to a dog clutching a bone in its mouth.



Veteran actor Naseeruddin Shah slammed Bollywood's silence on CJP protests

"They'll do it when their conscience tells them to. There's a saying: 'A dog with a bone in its mouth can't bark'. As soon as the bone drops out of their mouth or it breaks their teeth, then they will bark," Naseeruddin told 'The Wire', as quoted by 'The Indian Express'. "When further asked if he thought people were taking advantage of others' silence by choosing to suppress their own conscience, Shah responded, "Absolutely, yeah." He went on to add, "But how long can they keep doing that? Only time will tell." Recently, Shah posted a video statement on social media, extending his support to the protesters. "I'd like to say two things to you all. The first thing is that if an uneducated person leads this country, then his heart will want the whole country to become as ignorant, incomprehensible and merciless as he is. After completing two illustrious acting courses from the National School of Drama (NSD) and the Film and Television Institute of India (FTII), what I have learned the most about the craft is from those children, whom I have

tried to teach," he said. "I sympathise with them. I am emotional and at the same time, my blood boils seeing how the youth are being tortured by those goons who remind me of the mask-wearing agents in America. Think about your own children too. One day, you will also have to face the consequences of your actions," the actor added. Shah went on to urge students not to lose hope, saying, "Many people are with you. Keep fighting. I have always expected a lot from the nation's youth and my confidence in them has only gotten stronger now. I'd also like to tell the Government: 'Sab yaad rakha jayega' (Everything shall be remembered)." AGENCIES

After 'Saiyaara', Ahaan Panday's YRF next to release in March 2027

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Yash Raj Films' (YRF) has fixed March 26, 2027 (Good Friday) as the theatrical release date for director Ali Abbas Zafar's untitled romantic action drama starring Ahaan Panday of 'Saiyaara' fame.

The film also stars Sharvari, Aishwary Thackeray and Bobby Deol in lead roles and has been extensively shot in the UK.

Produced by Aditya Chopra and directed by Ali Abbas Zafar, this film marks the fifth producer-director collaboration between them after 'Mere Brother Ki Dulhan', 'Gunday', 'Sultan'

The film also stars Sharvari, Aishwary Thackeray and Bobby Deol in lead roles

and 'Tiger Zinda Hai'. Except for 'Mere Brother Ki Dulhan', the other three films were major box office successes.

Given the humongous box office record of 'Saiyaara', a musical romantic film directed by Mohit Suri last year, which marked the debut of Ahaan, there's indeed pressure on Zafar to deliver another mega hit.



'The Odyssey' earns over Rs 100 crore at box office

Filmmaker Christopher Nolan's "The Odyssey" has earned over Rs 100 crore at the domestic box office in the first week of release, emerging as the biggest Hollywood film of the year.



The film went on to earn over Rs 70 crore in India during the opening weekend

Featuring Matt Damon as Odysseus, Tom Holland as Telemachus, Zendaya as Athena, Robert Pattinson as Aeneas, Lupita Nyong'o as Helen of Troy and Clytemnestra, Anne Hathaway as Penelope and Charlize Theron as Calypso, among others, the film released globally on July 17. The film went on to earn over Rs 70 crore in India during the opening weekend. Also, it turned out to be another release for the filmmaker to earn over Rs 100 crore at the box office after 'Oppenheimer', according to a press release. "A journey is measured by distance, not by how it begins. The Odyssey's opening told us India was ready to show up. What has followed since,

audiences returning day after day to fill every cinema screen available, tells us something more valuable. This is trust, not a moment. Crossing Rs 100 crore within a week is a number," Denzil Dias, vice president and managing director, 'Warner Bros Pictures India', said.

He added, "What it represents is simpler. A packed house of strangers, gasping and cheering together, choosing the one place a story this size was built to be seen. That is what a cinema screen gives audiences that nothing else can."

"The Odyssey" revolves around the Greek King Odysseus (played by Damon) on a perilous 10-year journey home after the Trojan War. Beset by vengeful gods, sea monsters and enchantresses, he fights to reunite with his wife, Penelope (Hathaway) and son, Telemachus (Holland).

PTI

'NOTHING CAN HEAL MILLIONS OF HEARTS THAT ARE BROKEN'

Dia Mirza criticised PM Narendra Modi's message to the nation over the NEET paper leak

Bollywood actress Dia Mirza slammed Prime Minister Narendra Modi's latest message to the nation over the NEET paper leak. The 'Ikka' star stated that his remarks lacked empathy for the students and families affected by the crisis.

Hours after the Prime Minister's video message on July 23, the actress shared a strongly worded note on her 'Instagram' handle, in which she expressed her disappointment over his late response.

"Not one word of empathy for the parents who have lost their children, for the children who have died, for the incredible resilience of students demanding their rights, for Sonam ji and the students who were on a hunger strike

for weeks. How hard can it be, Sir?" she wrote.

Dia further questioned the Prime Minister's very delayed response: "It took 47 days for you to say something. And now that you have, you have said nothing. Nothing that can heal the millions of hearts that are broken."

Mirza's post received support from several social media users. One 'Instagram' user wrote, "You the best! Thanks for calling it out! (sic)." Another commented, "Hell yes. Thanks for seeing it through. And what bothers me is that all these celebrities and people are believing that message? They just want to get back to regular business (sic)." In a nearly three-minute

video message posted at 11:52 pm on July 23, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said examination paper leaks had caused 'immense pain' to lakhs of students and their parents. He further announced that the Union Cabinet would discuss a draft law on Friday to introduce fast-track courts and stricter punishment for those involved in paper leak cases. He also said the government would make every effort to pass the proposed legislation during the ongoing Monsoon Session of Parliament.

Calling the issue 'not a minor one', the Prime Minister said the government's immediate priority after the NEET paper leak was to ensure that students didn't lose an academic year. AGENCIES



The Bengal girl made history by becoming the first Indian filmmaker to win the Best Director Award in the 'Orizzonti Section' at the 82nd Venice International Film Festival for her debut feature 'Songs Of Forgotten Trees'

Sarin, Kajal Keshav and Vinod Suryavanshi.

"Returning to the 'Orizzonti Competition', after 'Songs of Forgotten Trees' last year, is both humbling and deeply emotional. This recognition belongs to the entire team who poured their hearts into the film and I hope it encourages more honest, fearless and deeply human stories to find their audience," said Roy.

The 32-year-old director, who hails from Purulia district in West Bengal, informed that

her recent film draws from her own life as a migrant, watching working-class lives slowly dissolve into the restless pulse of the city. "The film is about people who dare to desire in a world that punishes feelings, a gay man bound by duty, a woman yearning to be seen and a thief craving acceptance," she said.

Roy also mentioned how a bonded labourer from her hometown, Ameena, inspired her to make 'Lovers In The Blue Night'.

In her strongly worded 'Instagram' note, she expressed her disappointment over his late response

